

ADP 6-0

Command and Control



July 2026

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HEADQUARTERS, DEPARTMENT OF THE ARMY

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Command and Control

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Preface

ADP 6-0, *Command and Control*, provides doctrine on the fundamentals of command and control and the command and control warfighting function. Additionally, it describes the mission command approach to command and control. Through this approach, commanders combine the art and science of command and control to understand situations, make decisions, direct actions, and lead forces toward mission accomplishment.

Applicable to all members of the Army profession, the principal audience for ADP 6-0 is Army commanders, leaders, and unit staffs. It applies to Army forces during the conduct of operations and to Army forces performing duties at a home station. ADP 6-0 provides the foundation for training and Army education system curricula concerning command and control of Army forces.

To comprehend ADP 6-0, readers should understand the fundamentals of multidomain operations described in ADP 3-0 and the fundamentals of leadership described in ADP 6-22. As the operations process is the framework for exercising command and control, readers must also understand the fundamentals of the operations process established in ADP 5-0. Details on the command and control system are found in FM 6-0.

ADP 6-0 implements North Atlantic Treaty Organization standardization agreement 2199. The Army historically fights with joint and multinational partners as part of a coalition, and ADP 6-0 is nested with joint and multinational doctrine. Army headquarters serving as a joint task force or multinational headquarters should also refer to applicable joint or multinational doctrine concerning command and control of joint or multinational forces.

Commanders, staffs, and subordinates ensure their decisions and actions comply with applicable U.S., international, and host nation laws and regulations when applying this doctrine. Commanders at all levels ensure their Soldiers operate in accordance with the law of armed conflict and the rules of engagement as discussed in FM 6-27/ MCTP 11-10C. They also adhere to the Army ethic described in ADP 6-22.

ADP 6-0 uses joint terms where applicable. Selected joint and Army terms and definitions appear in both the glossary and the text. Terms for which ADP 6-0 is the proponent publication are marked with an asterisk (*) in the glossary. Definitions for which ADP 6-0 is the proponent publication are boldfaced in the text. For other definitions shown in the text, the term is italicized and the number of the proponent publication follows the definition.

The proponent of ADP 6-0 is the United States Army Combined Arms Command. The preparing agency is the Combined Arms Doctrine Directorate, Mission Command Center of Excellence. Send comments and recommendations on a DA Form 2028 (*Recommended Changes to Publications and Blank Forms*) to Commander, U.S. Army Combined Arms Command and Fort Leavenworth, ATTN: ATZL-MCD (ADP 6-0), 300 McPherson Avenue, Fort Leavenworth, KS 66027-2337; by email to usarmy.leavenworth.mccoe.mbx.cadd-org-mailbox@army.mil; or submit an electronic DA Form 2028.

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Introduction

Command and control is fundamental to the art and science of warfare. It is the exercise of authority and direction by a properly designated commander over assigned and attached forces. No single specialized military function, either by itself or combined with others, has a purpose without it. Commanders are responsible for command and control. Through command and control, commanders provide purpose and direction to integrate all military activities towards a common goal—mission accomplishment.

The nature of war and the patterns of military history, however, show that war is not predictable or orderly. War is both a contest of wills and a contest of intellect between two or more sides in conflict, with each trying to alter the behavior of the other side. The complexity of friendly and enemy organizations, unique combinations of terrain and weather, and the dynamic interaction among all participants create uncertainty. Chance and friction increase the potential for chaos during operations.

As the Army's approach to command and control, mission command empowers subordinate decision making and decentralized execution appropriate to the situation. Mission command focuses on the objective of an operation, not on how to achieve it. It emphasizes timely decision making, understanding of the higher commander's intent, and the clear responsibility of subordinates to act within that intent to achieve the desired end state. With the commander's intent to provide unity of effort, mission command relies on decentralized execution and the initiative of subordinates.

Mission command requires tactically and technically competent commanders, staffs, and subordinate leaders operating in an environment of mutual trust and shared understanding. It requires building effective teams and a command climate in which commanders encourage subordinates to make decisions at the appropriate level and exercise disciplined initiative to seize opportunities and counter threats within the commander's intent. Through mission orders, commanders focus their subordinates on the purpose of an operation rather than on the details of how to perform assigned tasks. This allows subordinates the greatest possible freedom of action in the context of a particular situation. When delegating authority to subordinates, commanders set the necessary conditions for success by allocating resources and describing levels of risk tolerance to subordinates based on assigned tasks.

Aspects of mission command—including commander's intent, mutual trust, disciplined initiative, and mission orders—have long been part of U.S. Army culture. General Grant's orders to Sherman for the campaign of 1864 and Sherman's supporting plan are models of clear commander's intent, mission orders, and understanding based on mutual trust (See vignette on page 11). A more recent example is the 3rd Infantry Division's march to Baghdad in 2003 and the subsequent "thunder runs" that showed the world that the Iraqi regime was defeated. Thunder Run was successful because the corps and division-level commanders established clear intent in their orders and trusted their subordinates' judgment and abilities to exercise disciplined initiative in response to a fluid, complex problem, underwriting the risks that they took.

The Army codified the term mission command and its principles in the 2003 edition of FM 6-0. As the Army's first manual dedicated to command and control, FM 6-0 addressed the fundamentals of command and control and described mission command as the Army's preferred concept for exercising command and control.

The 2012 edition of ADP 6-0 significantly revised Army command and control doctrine. It rescinded the term command and control for Army forces and replaced it with mission command. The term mission command became an activity, a warfighting function, a system, and a philosophy. The use of the term mission command to describe multiple things created ambiguity. Mission command replaced command and control, but in practical application it meant the same thing. This led to differing expectations among leadership cohorts regarding the appropriate application of mission command during operations and garrison activities. Labeling multiple things mission command eroded the importance of mission command as the approach to exercising command and control.

The 2019 edition of ADP 6-0 realigned Army command and control doctrine with joint, other service, and allied doctrine that use the term command and control. Like the 2003 edition of FM 6-0, the 2019 edition of ADP 6-0 once again described the fundamentals of command and control and defined mission command as the Army approach for its exercise.

This version of ADP 6-0 represents key updates to the 2019 edition as it relates to the current operating environment. Due to the vulnerabilities of large, static headquarters on the modern battlefield, command posts are no longer the singular center point of command and control. In order to remain survivable, commanders organize and operate their command and control system in a dispersed manner through a series of command and control nodes. Other key updates and changes to this version of ADP 6-0 include—

- Incorporating the Army's operational concept of multidomain operations and related doctrine established in FM 3-0.
- Accounting for technical advancements that enhance friendly command and control.
- Accounting for threat capabilities that can affect friendly command and control.
- Incorporating the role of technology and data in supporting the science of control and the command and control system.
- Adjustments to the command and control system to include people, processes, data and networks, and command and control nodes.

ADP 6-0 consists of 4 chapters:

Chapter 1 sets the context for understanding command and control by describing the nature of war and summarizing the Army's operational concept. Next, it defines and describes command and control, their relationship to each other, and their elements. The chapter then defines and describes mission command—the Army's approach to command and control. The chapter concludes with an overview of the command and control warfighting function and the impact of technology on controlling operations.

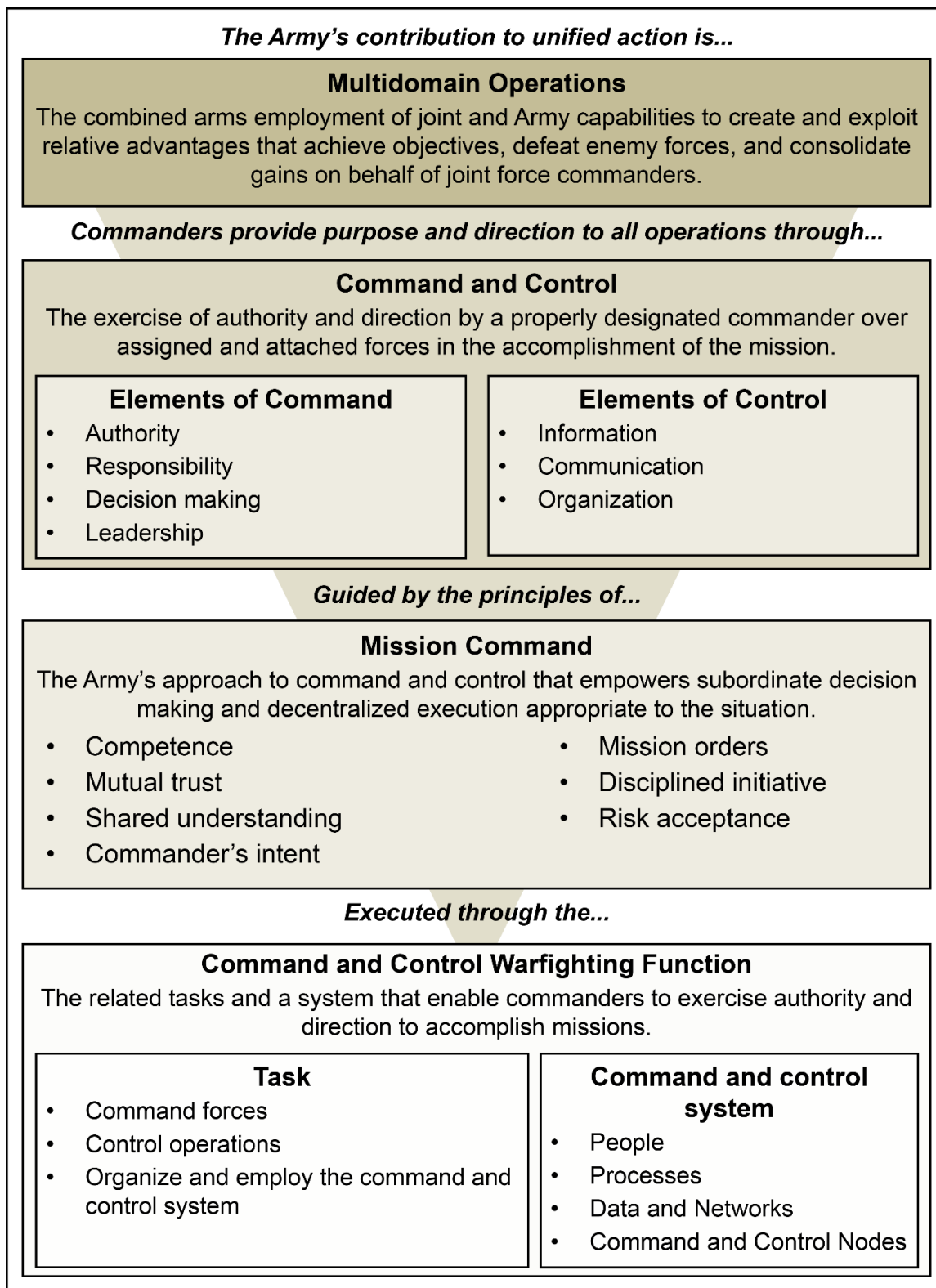
Chapter 2 provides a discussion of the nature and elements of command. It then describes the role of the commander in operations. The chapter concludes with a discussion on effective command.

Chapter 3 begins with a discussion of the nature of control and its elements. A discussion of control measures follows. The chapter concludes with a discussion on effective control.

Chapter 4 defines and describes the command and control warfighting function. It begins with a discussion of the command and control tasks, followed by a discussion of the command and control system. The chapter concludes with a discussion on organizing the command and control system.

Introductory Figure on page vii provides the ADP 6-0 logic map that shows how commanders provide purpose and direction to all operations through command and control, guided by the principles of mission command and executed through the command and control warfighting function.

Certain terms for which ADP 6-0 is the proponent have been added or modified. The glossary contains acronyms and defined terms. See Introductory Table on page viii for a listing of new and modified Army terms.



Introductory Figure. Logic Map

Introductory Table. New and Modified Army Terms

<i>Term</i>	<i>Reasoning</i>
command and control node	New term and definition.
command and control system	ADP 6-0 modifies definition.
data	ADP 6-0 modifies definition.
data analytics	New term and definition
data literacy	New term and definition
knowledge management	ADP 6-0 modifies definition.

Chapter 1

Fundamentals of Command and Control

This chapter sets the context for understanding command and control (C2) by first describing the nature of war and summarizing the Army's operational concept. Next, it defines and describes C2, their relationship to each other, and their elements. The chapter then defines and describes mission command—the Army's approach to the exercise of C2. The chapter concludes with an overview of the C2 warfighting function.

THE NATURE OF WAR

1-1. Military operations fall along a competition continuum that spans from competition to armed conflict. Violent power struggles in failed states, along with foreign powers seeking to gain strategic advantage, present challenges to the joint force. Army forces must be prepared to meet these challenges across the entire range of military operations.

Exercising effective C2 begins with an appreciation for the chaotic and uncertain nature of war.

1-2. The range of military operations helps relate military activities and operations in scope and purpose against the backdrop of the competition continuum. The potential range of military activities and operations extends from military engagement, security cooperation, and deterrence, up through large-scale combat operations. Whether countering terrorism as part of a limited contingency operation or defeating great powers in large-scale combat, the nature of war is constant. War is—

- Fought to achieve a political purpose.
- A human endeavor.
- Chaotic and uncertain.

FOUGHT TO ACHIEVE A POLITICAL PURPOSE

1-3. All U.S. military operations share a common purpose: to achieve or contribute to national policy objectives. An objective directs every military operation towards a clearly defined, decisive, and attainable goal. Objectives reinforce the proper relationship between military operations and policy. War is always subordinate to policy and serves a political end. In conjunction with political leaders, military leaders develop strategies to achieve the desired policy outcomes. Policy outcomes often relate to the nation's ability to influence, control, or secure populations, civil infrastructure, natural resources, and access to global commons in all domains.

HUMAN ENDEAVOR

1-4. War is a human endeavor—a clash of wills characterized by the threat or application of force and violence, often fought among populations. It is not a mechanical process that can be precisely controlled by machines, calculations, or processes. It is not conducted in carefully controlled and predictable environments. Fundamentally, all war is about changing human behavior. During operations, Army forces face adaptive enemies while managing the will of its force and perception from inside and outside of an assigned area. As friendly forces seek to impose their will on enemy forces, enemy forces resist and seek to impose their will on friendly forces. A similar dynamic occurs among civilian groups whose own desires influence and are influenced by military operations. All sides act, react, learn, and adapt. Appreciating these relationships is essential to understanding the fundamental nature of war.

CHAOTIC AND UNCERTAIN

1-5. War, especially land combat, is inherently chaotic and uncertain. The complexity of friendly and enemy organizations, unique combinations of terrain and weather, and the dynamic interaction among all participants create uncertainty. Chance and friction, always present on the battlefield, further increase the potential for chaos and uncertainty during operations. Chance refers to unexpected events or changes beyond the control of friendly forces, while friction describes the challenges that make the execution of even simple tasks difficult. Both are always present for all sides during combat.

1-6. The scale, scope, tempo, and lethality of large-scale combat operations intensify the dynamic and uncertain nature of war, making precise cause-and-effect determinations difficult. The unintended effects of operations often cannot be anticipated and may not be readily apparent. The nature of war demands an approach to the C2 of operations that does not attempt to impose perfect order but rather makes allowances for uncertainty created by chance and friction.

ARMY OPERATIONS

1-7. The primary responsibility of our Army is to conduct prompt and sustained land combat as part of the joint force (ADP 1). Army forces accomplish their missions by conducting operations on behalf of a joint force commander. An *operation* is a sequence of tactical actions with a common purpose or unifying theme (JP 1, Volume 1). The tenants and imperatives of multidomain operations guide Army forces during the conduct of operations. *Multidomain operations* are the combined arms employment of joint and Army capabilities to create and exploit relative advantages to achieve objectives, defeat enemy forces, and consolidate gains on behalf of joint force commanders (ADP 3-0).

1-8. Multidomain operations are the Army's contribution to joint campaigns during competition, crisis, and armed conflict. Below the threshold of armed conflict, multidomain operations are how Army forces accrue advantages and demonstrate readiness for conflict. This deters adversaries while assuring allies and partners. During armed conflict, Army forces conduct multidomain operations to close with and destroy the enemy, defeat enemy formations, seize critical terrain, and control populations and resources to deliver sustainable political outcomes.

1-9. Throughout operations, Army forces employ capabilities in multiple domains; request capabilities from their higher headquarters; and continuously benefit from maritime, air, space, and cyberspace capabilities that they do not control. Space-based global positioning and satellite communications are examples of capabilities from which Army forces benefit but do not necessarily control. Lower echelons may not always notice the opportunities created by higher echelons or other forces that operate primarily in other domains. Leaders seek to understand these opportunities and how the absence of those opportunities affects their concepts of operations, decision making, and risk assessment. (Refer to FM 3-0 for a detailed discussion of multidomain operations, including its tenets and imperatives.)

Central to multidomain operations is the combined arms employment of all available joint and Army capabilities to create and exploit physical, human, and information advantages to achieve objectives.

ARMY COMMAND AND CONTROL

1-10. Central to all operations is C2. *Command and control* is the exercise of authority and direction by a properly designated commander over assigned and attached forces in the accomplishment of the mission (JP 1, Volume 2). C2 is fundamental to the art and science of warfare. No single activity in operations is more important than C2. C2 by itself will not secure an objective, destroy an enemy target, or deliver supplies. Yet none of these activities could be coordinated towards a common objective, or synchronized to achieve maximum effect, without effective C2. It is through C2 that the activities a military force performs gain purpose and direction. The goal of C2 is mission accomplishment.

Through C2, commanders provide purpose and direction to integrate all military activities towards a common goal—mission accomplishment.

1-11. The focal point of C2 is the commander. Commanders assess situations, make decisions, and direct action. They provide purpose, direction, and motivation to instill the will to win. Commanders seek to understand the situation, visualize an end state and operational approach, and describe that end state and operational approach in their commander's intent and planning guidance. During execution, commanders direct the actions of subordinates. They then adjust operations based on changes to the situation and feedback from subordinate units, external organizations, and their staffs.

1-12. Commanders counter the effects of enemy action, fog, and friction to make decisions and direct action through C2. C2 is multidirectional, with feedback from forces and external organizations as shown in Figure 1-1. It includes the reciprocal communication of information between commanders, staffs, subordinates, and

other organizations in an assigned area as they work to achieve shared understanding and adjust to continuously changing circumstances.

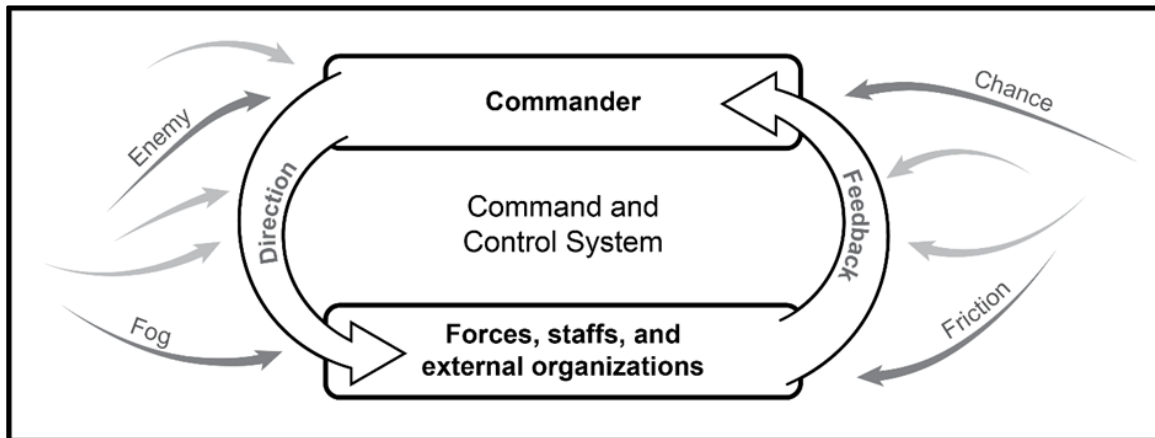


Figure 1-1. Reciprocal Nature of Command and Control

1-13. Commanders cannot exercise C2 alone. Even at the lowest levels, commanders need support to exercise C2. To effectively exercise C2, commanders are supported by the C2 system. The C2 system is the arrangement of people, processes, data and networks, and C2 nodes. (See Chapter 4 for a discussion of the C2 system.)

1-14. The Army's framework for organizing and putting C2 into action is the operations process. The *operations process* is the major command and control activities performed during operations: planning, preparing, executing, and continuously assessing the operation (ADP 5-0). This is shown in Figure 1-2.

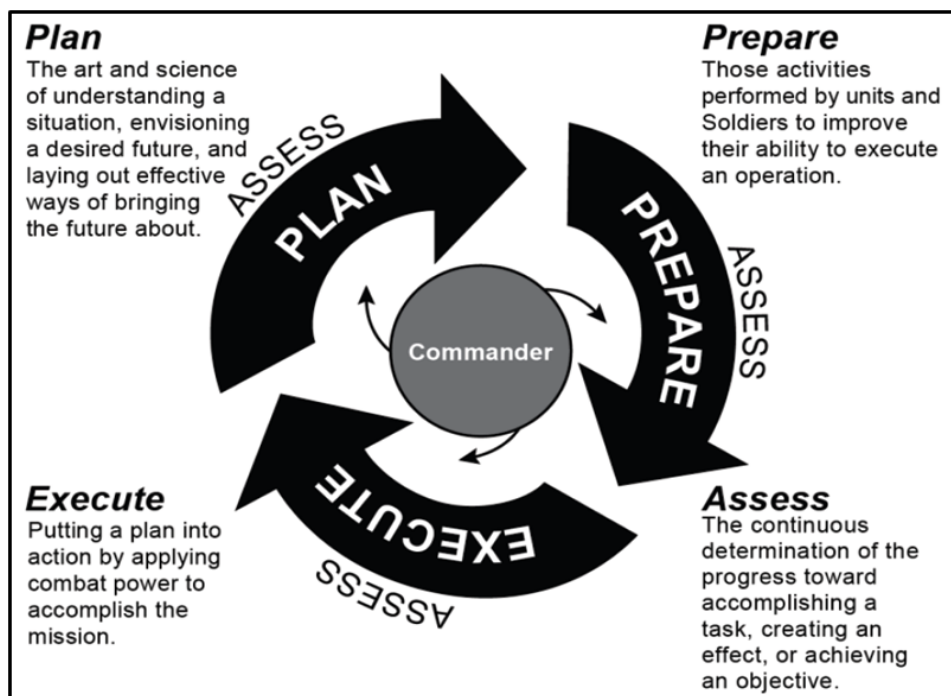


Figure 1-2. The Operations Process

1-15. The activities of the operations process are not separate; they overlap and recur as circumstances demand. Planning, preparing, and executing do not always have distinct start and end points. Planning is a continuous activity within the process. While preparing for one operation, or during its execution, units are

refining the current plan or planning for future operations. Preparation always overlaps with planning, and it continues throughout execution for some subordinate units. Assessing surrounds the other three activities as commanders and staffs judge progress toward accomplishing tasks and achieving objectives. Subordinate echelons or units within the same command may be in different stages of the operations process at any given time. (Refer to ADP 5-0 for a detailed discussion of the operations process.)

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN COMMAND AND CONTROL

1-16. C2 are interrelated. Command resides with commanders. It includes the authority and responsibility for effectively using available resources and for planning the employment of, organizing, directing, coordinating, and controlling military forces for the accomplishment of missions. It also includes responsibility for the health, welfare, morale, and discipline of assigned personnel. Command emphasizes a commander's lawful assignment of authority and the responsibility that accompanies that authority.

1-17. Effective command is impossible without control. Control is inherent in command. It includes the regulation of forces and warfighting functions. Commanders, supported by their staffs, control operations by receiving and communicating information. This builds shared understanding and directs, coordinates, and synchronizes the actions of subordinate units. Commander's intent, orders, control measures, and standard operating procedures all assist with the control of operations. Determining the appropriate level of control in a particular situation is a critical command responsibility.

Command

1-18. *Command* is the authority that a commander in the armed forces lawfully exercises over subordinates by virtue of rank or assignment (JP 1, Volume 2). Command is personal—an individual person commands, not an organization or a headquarters. Command is considered more art than science, because it includes intangible elements that require judgment in application. The elements of command are—

- Authority.
- Responsibility.
- Decision making.
- Leadership.

1-19. Inherent in command is the authority that a military commander lawfully exercises over subordinates, including the authority to assign tasks and the responsibility for their successful completion. Authority derives from two sources: official authority and personal authority. Official authority is a function of rank and position, and it is bestowed by law and regulation. The authority to enforce orders by law is one of the key elements of command, and it distinguishes military commanders from other leaders and managers. Personal authority is a function of personal influence. It derives from factors such as experience, reputation, skill, character, and personal example. It is bestowed by the other members of the organization. Official authority provides the power to act, but it is rarely enough for success on its own. The most effective commanders also possess a high degree of personal authority.

1-20. With authority comes responsibility. Commanders are legally and ethically responsible for their decisions and for the actions, accomplishments, and failures of their subordinates. Commanders may delegate authority, but delegation does not absolve commanders of their responsibility to the higher echelon commander. Commanders are always accountable for what happens or fails to happen in their command.

1-21. Commanders exercise their authority through decision making. Decision making involves selecting the most favorable course of action to accomplish the mission, including adjusting plans based on changing circumstances. Effective decision making relies on data to help commanders and staffs develop understanding and make informed decisions. Historically, commanders have leveraged advancements in technology to gain advantages in decision making, a practice known as decision optimization. Current decision optimization efforts are actively integrating artificial intelligence and advanced analytics to facilitate faster, more informed decision making in today's dynamic environment. This integration enables units to synthesize information and combine human and machine capabilities, providing the necessary capacity and speed for decision making to achieve an operational advantage.

1-22. Decision making includes knowing when and what to decide while understanding the consequences of those decisions. Commanders apply their understanding, visualization, description, and direction to make

and communicate their decisions. They draw on their education, experience, knowledge, and judgment to exercise their authority while planning how to achieve the end state and lead their forces during preparation and execution, continually assessing progress.

1-23. Leadership involves influencing people by providing purpose, direction, and motivation to accomplish the mission and improve the organization. It is the unifying and multiplying element of combat power. Commanders lead through personal example, persuasion, and compulsion. This translates their decisions into effective action by their forces. (See chapter 2 for more information on command.)

Control

1-24. **Control is the regulation of forces and warfighting functions to accomplish the mission in accordance with the commander's intent.** Commanders exercise control over all forces in their assigned area, aided by their C2 system (people, process, data and networks, and C2 nodes). Staff aid the commander in exercising control by supporting the commander's decision making, assisting subordinate units, and informing external organizations.

1-25. Control is more science than art because it relies on objectivity, empirical methods, and data driven analysis. Control requires commanders and staffs to understand and assess the measurable aspects of operations. These include the physical capabilities and limitations of friendly and enemy organizations and systems. Control involves interpreting and applying data to evaluate operational conditions, monitor progress, and adjust plans as needed. Control also requires a realistic appreciation for time and distance factors and the time required to initiate and complete certain actions. Units are bound by factors such as movement rates, supply consumption, weapons effects, and ethical and legal considerations. Computing and communication technologies such as artificial intelligence, machine learning, and mesh networks significantly contribute to effective C2. Commanders and staffs use these technologies to analyze vast amounts of data and identify patterns, resulting in enhanced situational understanding and decision making. The proper application of control incorporates some level of art, since commanders use judgment regarding the abilities of subordinates and the likelihood that friction is part of every operation. The elements of control are—

- Information.
- Communication.
- Organization.

1-26. Information provides the basis for situational understanding, decision making, and directing actions across all warfighting functions. Army forces rely on processing data and analyzing information to understand situations and make informed decisions. Staffs provide commanders with accurate and relevant information, which requires access to reliable data and effective analysis. Commanders determine information requirements and set information priorities. Equally important, commanders and staffs remain aware of the limitations, risks, and potential threats associated with the information they rely on. Commanders and staffs identify, interpret, and apply relevant information to make decisions.

Information is central to all activities Army forces undertake.

1-27. Communication is the use of any means or method to convey information from one person or place to another. Army forces employ to exercise control over forces by linking information and data to decisions and decisions to action. Army leaders communicate data and information through networks to build and share a common operational picture (COP), which enables coordinated action across the force. Commanders anticipate those times when communication is likely to be intermittent, and they adjust their level of control accordingly.

1-28. Commanders establish and maintain control through organization. Organizational considerations are both internal (organizing the C2 system) and external (establishing command and support relationships among subordinate forces). Commanders internally arrange the C2 system to synchronize activities, which supports the commander's decision making and the effective conduct of operations. They task organize the force through command and support relationships to weight the main effort and ensure forces are resourced to accomplish assigned tasks. (See Chapter 3 for more information on control.)

JOINT COMMAND AND CONTROL CONSIDERATIONS

1-29. Army forces conduct operations as part of a joint force. A *joint force* is a force composed of significant elements, assigned or attached, of two or more Military Departments that operate under a single joint force commander (JP 1, Volume 1). Army forces that are a direct subordinate unit to a joint force commander utilize joint C2 doctrine, techniques, and procedures. Theater armies, Army forces headquarters, and corps routinely interface with joint and other component headquarters throughout the conduct of operations. Key joint C2 considerations include—

- Joint command and support relationships (refer to JP 1, Volume 2).
 - Command relationships with the joint force commander.
 - Command relationships among components.
 - Functional component support and supporting relationships.
 - Command relationships with forces made available.
- Joint task force headquarters organization and staff operations (refer to JP 3-33).
- Joint planning (refer to JP 5-0).
- Joint intelligence and intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance synchronization (refer to JP 2-0).
- Joint operations in the information environment (refer to JP 3-04).
- Joint communications (refer to JP 6-0).
- Joint all-domain operations coordination and synchronization (refer to JP 3-0).

1-30. Within joint operations, Army forces employ capabilities from all domains (land, air, maritime, space, and cyberspace). Each domain has a unique set of characteristics that influences how capabilities are integrated and synchronized throughout a joint operation. Army forces understand the joint authorities, processes, procedures, and time it takes to receive and assess effects from other domains and for Army forces to create effects in those domains.

1-31. Army forces have effectively integrated capabilities and synchronized actions in the land, air, and maritime domains for decades, and the authorities, processes, and procedures are well established. However, the military application of technologies to space and cyberspace domains requires special consideration in planning and execution. (Refer to JP 3-12 and JP 3-14 for more information on the military application in space and cyberspace domains.)

COMMAND AND CONTROL IN MULTINATIONAL ENVIRONMENTS

1-32. *Multinational operations* is a collective term to describe military actions conducted by forces of two or more nations, usually undertaken within the structure of a coalition or alliance (JP 3-16). Multinational operations are driven by a common agreement among the participating alliance or coalition partners. While each nation has its own interests and participates within the limitations of national caveats, all nations bring value to an operation. Each nation's force has unique capabilities, and each usually contributes to the operation's legitimacy in terms of international or local acceptability.

1-33. The multinational force commander directs the military effort to reach a common objective. Nations create a multinational force once those nations reach a common interest. Each multinational operation is specific. Each national commander who is part of a multinational force is responsible to the commander of the multinational force and the national chain of command. Contributing nations maintain a direct line of communications to their national headquarters and their own national governments.

1-34. Army forces anticipate that most operations will be multinational operations and plan accordingly. Key multinational C2 considerations include—

- Chains of command (national and multinational).
- Authorities and command relationships.
- Command structure (lead nation, parallel, integrated, combination).
- Staff organization.
- Interoperability (technical and procedural).
- Communications.
- Information and intelligence sharing.
- Liaison and coordination centers.

1-35. FM 3-16 discusses each of these considerations in detail. Multinational operations present unique C2 challenges. These include cultural and language barriers, interoperability challenges, national caveats on the use of respective forces, the sharing of information and intelligence, and rules of engagement. Establishing standard operating procedures and liaison with multinational partners is critical to effective C2. When conducting multinational training or operations, Army commanders should be familiar with multinational doctrine and standards ratified by the U.S. For example, Allied Tactical Publication 3.2.2 applies to Army forces during the conduct of North Atlantic Treaty Organization operations.

1-36. Liaison officers and noncommissioned officers support effective C2 by enabling shared understanding, coordination, and synchronization. Liaison officers represent the commander, facilitate information exchange, and help integrate capabilities across echelons and organizations. Organizations such as security force assistance brigades and Theater Liaison Detachments provide trained, purpose-built teams that enhance interoperability, maintain habitual relationships, and enable mission command in complex operating environments. Through these organizations, commanders extend their operational reach, reduce friction, and improve the integration of multinational, joint, and interorganizational efforts.

MISSION COMMAND

1-37. **Mission command is the Army's approach to command and control that empowers subordinate decision making and decentralized execution appropriate to the situation.** Mission command is based on the Army's view that war is inherently chaotic and uncertain. No plan can account for every possibility, and most plans change rapidly during execution to account for changes in the situation. No single person is ever sufficiently informed to make every important decision, nor can a single person keep up with the number of decisions that need to be made during combat. As such, mission command empowers subordinate leaders to make decisions and act within the commander's intent to exploit opportunities and counter threats.

1-38. Subordinate leaders often have a better understanding of what is happening in their area than higher echelon commanders have. They are more likely to respond effectively to threats and fleeting opportunities if allowed to make decisions and act based on changing situations and unforeseen events. Enemy forces may behave differently than expected, a route may become impassable, or units could consume supplies at unexpected rates. Friction and unforeseeable combinations of variables impose uncertainty in all operations. This requires an approach to C2 that does not attempt to impose perfect order but rather accepts uncertainty and makes allowances for unpredictability.

1-39. Mission command capitalizes on subordinate ingenuity, innovation, and decision making to achieve the commander's intent when conditions change or current orders are no longer relevant. It requires subordinates who seek opportunities and commanders who accept risk for subordinates trying to meet their intent. Subordinate decision making and decentralized execution appropriate to the situation help manage uncertainty and tempo at each echelon during operations. Employing the mission command approach during all garrison activities and training events is essential to creating the cultural foundation for its employment in high-risk environments.

SUBORDINATE DECISION MAKING

1-40. Successful commanders anticipate future events by developing branches and sequels instead of focusing on details better handled by subordinates during current operations. The higher the echelon, the more time commanders devote to future operations and the broader the guidance provided to subordinates. Subordinates empowered to make decisions during operations unburden higher commanders from issues that distract from focus on broader perspective and critical issues.

1-41. Commanders delegate appropriate authority to deputies, subordinate commanders, and staff members based on a judgment of their capabilities and experience. Delegation allows subordinates to decide and act for their commander in specified areas. Delegating decision-making authority reduces the number of decisions made at the higher echelons and the response time at lower echelons. In addition to determining the amount of decision-making authority they will delegate, commanders also identify decisions that are their sole responsibility and cannot be delegated to subordinates.

1-42. When delegating authority to subordinates, commanders strive to set the necessary conditions for success. They do this by assessing and managing risk. Risk is inherent at all levels of command. Commanders and staffs assess hazards and recommend controls to help manage risk, rather than forcing risk decisions on

subordinates that should be determined at higher echelons. Risk, including ethical risk, is identified and mitigated by the higher-level commander to the greatest extent possible. There are two ways of managing risk: by prioritizing and controlling the number of tasks assigned to subordinates, and by providing the appropriate resources to accomplish those tasks. These resources include information, forces, materiel, and time.

1-43. While commanders can delegate authority, they cannot delegate responsibility. Subordinates are accountable to their commanders for the use of delegated authority, but commanders remain solely responsible and accountable for the actions of their subordinates.

DECENTRALIZED EXECUTION

1-44. Decentralized execution is the delegation of decision-making authority to subordinates, done so they may make and implement decisions and adjust their assigned tasks in fluid and rapidly changing situations. Decentralized execution is essential to seizing, retaining, and exploiting the initiative during operations in environments where conditions rapidly change and uncertainty is the norm. Rapidly changing situations and uncertainty are inherent in operations where commanders seek to establish a tempo and intensity that enemy forces cannot match.

1-45. Decentralized execution requires disseminating information to the lowest possible level so subordinates can make informed decisions based on a shared understanding of both the situation and their commander's intent. This empowers subordinates operating in rapidly changing conditions to exercise disciplined initiative within their commander's intent. It is the duty of subordinates to exercise initiative to achieve their commander's intent. It is the commander's responsibility to issue appropriate intent and ensure subordinates are prepared in terms of education, training, and experience to exercise initiative.

1-46. The commander's intent provides a unifying idea that allows decentralized execution within an overarching framework. It provides guidance within which individuals exercise initiative to accomplish the desired end state. Understanding the commander's intent two echelons up further enhances unity of effort while providing the basis for decentralized decision making and execution throughout the depth of a formation. Subordinates who understand the commander's intent are far more likely to exercise initiative effectively in unexpected situations.

LEVELS OF CONTROL

1-47. Determining the appropriate level of control, including delegating authorities and determining how much decentralized execution to employ, is an essential aspect of mission command. The level and application of control is constantly evolving. It is continuously assessed and adjusted to ensure the level of control is appropriate to the situation. Commanders allow subordinates the greatest freedom of action equal to the level of acceptable risk in a particular situation. The mission variables (mission, enemy, terrain and weather, troops and support available, time available, civil considerations, and informational considerations) influence how much control to impose on subordinates. Other considerations include—

- Enemy disposition and capabilities.
- Level of integration and synchronization required.
- Higher echelon headquarters constraints.
- Level of risk.
- Level of legal and ethical ambiguity.
- Rules of engagement.
- Level of unit cohesion.
- Level of training.
- Level of trust.
- Level of shared understanding.

Figure 1-3 provides a sample of the considerations for determining the appropriate level of control.

← More control Less control →		
	Considerations	
- Predictable - Known	Situation	- Unpredictable - Unknown
- Inexperienced - New team	Unit Cohesion	- Experienced - Mature team
Untrained or needs practice	Level of Training	Trained in tasks to be performed
Being developed	Level of Trust	Established
- Top down - Prescriptive communications - Vertical communications	Shared Understanding	- Reciprocal information - Descriptive communications - Vertical and horizontal communications
Restrictive	Rules of Engagement	Permissive
Optimal decisions later	Required Decision	Acceptable decisions sooner
- Science of war - Synchronization	Appropriate To	- Art of war - Orchestration

Figure 1-3. Levels of Control

1-48. Different operations and phases of operations may require tighter or more relaxed control over subordinate elements than other phases. Operations that require the close synchronization of multiple units, or the integration of effects in a limited amount of time, may require more detailed coordination and be controlled in a more centralized manner. Examples of this include combined arms breaches, air assaults, and wet gap crossings. Conversely, operations that do not require the close coordination of multiple units, such as a movement to contact or a pursuit, offer many opportunities to exercise initiative. These opportunities may be lost if too much emphasis is placed on detailed synchronization. Even in a highly controlled operation, subordinates still exercise initiative to address unexpected problems and achieve their commander's intent when existing orders no longer make sense in the context of execution.

PRINCIPLES OF MISSION COMMAND

1-49. Mission command requires competent leaders and an environment of mutual trust and shared understanding among commanders, staffs, and subordinates. It requires effective teams and a command climate in which subordinates are required to seize opportunities and counter threats within the commander's intent. Commanders issue mission orders that focus on the purpose of an operation and essential coordination measures rather than the details of how to perform assigned tasks, giving subordinates the latitude to accomplish those tasks in a manner that best fits the situation. This minimizes the number of decisions a single commander makes and allows subordinates the greatest possible freedom of action to accomplish tasks. Finally, when delegating authority to subordinates, commanders set the necessary conditions for success by allocating appropriate resources to subordinates based on assigned tasks. Successful mission command is enabled by the principles of—

- Competence.
- Mutual trust.
- Shared understanding.
- Commander's intent.
- Mission orders.
- Disciplined initiative.
- Risk acceptance.

COMPETENCE

1-50. An organization's ability to operate using mission command relates directly to the competence of its Soldiers. Commanders and subordinates achieve the competence to perform assigned tasks to standard through training, education, assignment experience, and professional development. Commanders continually assess the competence of their subordinates and their organizations. This assessment informs the degree of trust commanders have in their subordinates' ability to execute mission orders in a decentralized fashion at acceptable levels of risk. (For more information on risk, see chapter 2.)

Tactically and technically competent commanders, subordinates, and teams are the basis of effective mission command.

1-51. The training and education that occurs in both schools and units provides commanders and subordinates with experiences that allow them to achieve professional competence. Repetitive, realistic, and challenging training creates common experiences that develop the teamwork, trust, and shared understanding that commanders need to exercise mission command and forces need to achieve unity of effort. (Refer to ADP 7-0 for doctrine on individual and collective training.)

1-52. Leaders supplement institutional and organizational training and education with continuous self-development. Self-development is particularly important for the skills that rely on the art of command, which is further developed by reading and studying the art of war. These skills can also be developed through coursework, simulations, and experience.

MUTUAL TRUST

1-53. Mutual trust is the shared confidence between commanders, subordinates, and partners that they can be relied on and are competent in performing their assigned tasks. There are few shortcuts to gaining the trust of others. Trust is given by leaders and subordinates and built over time based on common shared experiences. It is the result of upholding Army values and exercising leadership consistent with Army leadership principles. It is most effectively instilled by the leader's personal example.

1-54. Mutual trust is essential to successful mission command, and it must flow throughout the chain of command. Subordinates are more willing to exercise initiative when they believe their commander trusts them. They are also more willing to exercise initiative if they believe their commander will accept and support the outcome of their decisions. Likewise, commanders delegate greater authority to subordinates who have demonstrated tactical and technical competency and whose judgment they trust.

1-55. Commanders must also trust their colleagues who are commanding adjacent and supporting forces and must earn their trust as well. Such actions synchronize operations without requiring detailed instructions from higher echelons. Once established and sustained, trust allows each echelon to focus on operations as a whole instead of on the actions of individual subordinates.

1-56. Trust is based on personal qualities, such as professional competence, character, and commitment. Soldiers must see values in action before such actions become a basis for trust. Trust is built through shared experiences and training deliberately developed by commanders or through the conduct of operations. During shared experiences, two-way communication and interaction among commanders, subordinates, and Soldiers reinforces trust. Soldiers expect to see members of the chain of command accomplishing the mission, taking care of their welfare, and leading by example through shared hardships and danger.

1-57. Trust is also a product of a common background, a common military education, understanding of doctrine, and a common language for operations. In some situations, trust may be based solely on a common understanding of an approach to operations. This understanding creates a basic level of trust that, until proven otherwise, new team members or adjacent units will conduct operations to a common standard. During large-scale ground combat operations where task organizations change rapidly and often, commanders and staffs assume a basic level of trust regarding the level of competence among new teams. (Refer ADP 6-22 for doctrine on the Army profession and associated ethic that serve as the foundation for building mutual trust.)

Grant's Orders to Sherman, 1864

In a letter to Major General William T. Sherman dated 4 April 1864, Lieutenant General Ulysses S. Grant outlined his 1864 campaign plan. Lieutenant General Grant described Major General Sherman's role by writing the following: "It is my design, if the enemy keep quiet and allow me to take the initiative in the spring campaign, to work all parts of the army together, and somewhat towards a common centre.... You I propose to move against Johnston's army, to break it up and to get into the interior of the enemy's country as far as you can, inflicting all the damage you can against their War resources. I do not propose to lay down for you a plan of campaign, but simply to lay down the work it is desirable to have done and leave you free to execute it in your own way. Submit to me, however, as early as you can, your plan of operation."

Major General Sherman responded to Lieutenant General Grant immediately in a letter dated 10 April 1864. He sent Lieutenant General Grant his specific plan of operations, demonstrating that he understood Lieutenant General Grant's intent:

"...That we are now all to act in a common plan, converging on a common center, looks like enlightened war.... I will not let side issues draw me off from your main plan, in which I am to Knock Joe [Confederate General Joseph E.] Johnston, and do as much damage to the resources of the enemy as possible....I would ever bear in mind that Johnston is at all times to be kept so busy that he cannot, in any event, send any part of his command against you or [Union Major General Nathaniel P.] Banks."

SHARED UNDERSTANDING

1-58. A critical challenge for commanders, staffs, and unified action partners is creating shared understanding of an operational environment and operational approach. *Unified action partners* are those military forces, governmental and nongovernmental organizations, and elements of the private sector with whom Army forces plan, coordinate, synchronize, and integrate during the conduct of operations (ADP 3-0). Shared understanding of the situation, along with the flow of information to the lowest possible level, forms the basis for unity of effort and subordinates' initiative. Effective decentralized execution is not possible without shared understanding.

1-59. Shared understanding starts with the Army's doctrine and professional military education. These instill a common approach to the conduct of operations, a common professional language, and a common understanding of the principles of mission command. Army professionals understand the most current Army doctrine to ensure a minimum level of shared understanding for the conduct of operations. It is this shared understanding that allows even hastily task-organized units to operate effectively.

1-60. An important source of shared understanding is open and clear communications between leaders and Soldiers. Commanders and staffs actively create shared understanding throughout the operations process by sharing and questioning information, perceptions, and ideas. They collaboratively frame an operational environment and its problems, and then they visualize approaches to solving those problems. Collaboration is more than coordination. It is multiple people and organizations working together towards a common goal by sharing knowledge and building consensus. It requires a candid exchange of ideas or opinions among participants and encourages frank discussions in areas of disagreement. Commanders and their subordinates continuously communicate during planning and in execution to maintain shared understanding.

1-61. Commanders establish a culture of collaboration in their organization. They recognize that they do not know everything, and they recognize that they may have something to learn from even the most junior subordinate. Commanders establish a command climate by their personal example; coaching, counseling, and mentoring where collaboration routinely occurs throughout their organization. Successful commanders invest the time and effort to visit Soldiers, subordinate leaders, and unified action partners to understand their

issues and concerns. Through such interactions, subordinates and partners gain insight into their commander's leadership style and expectations.

1-62. Commanders develop shared understanding in their organizations through training and by creating an environment of collaboration and dialogue. Commanders also aid shared understanding by exhibiting characteristics that reinforce their spoken message. Units develop the ability to communicate through familiarity, trust, a shared philosophy, and experiences.

1-63. There is a hierarchical component of shared understanding. At each echelon of command, commanders have a slightly different understanding of the situation. Having a common perception of military problems does not imply any requirement to come to identical solutions; under mission command, understanding what outcome to achieve is more important than agreement on how to achieve it. Activities that can lead to shared understanding include collaboration among commanders and staffs, professional development meetings, terrain walks, and professional discussions.

COMMANDER'S INTENT

1-64. The *commander's intent* is a clear and concise expression of the purpose of an operation and the desired objectives and military end state (JP 3-0). The higher echelon commander's intent provides the basis for unity of effort throughout the force. Each commander's intent nests within the commander's intent two levels up.

1-65. During planning, the initial commander's intent drives course of action development. In execution, the commander's intent guides initiative as subordinates make decisions and take action when unforeseen opportunities arise or when countering threats. Commanders develop their intent statement personally. It must be easy to remember and clearly understood by commanders and staffs two echelons lower in the chain of command. The more concise the commander's intent, the easier it is to understand and recall.

1-66. Commanders convey their intent in a format they determine most suitable to the situation. It includes the operation's purpose, key tasks, and conditions that define the end state. When describing the purpose of the operation, the commander's intent does not restate the "why" of the mission statement. Rather, it describes the broader purpose of the unit's operation in relationship to the higher commander's intent and concept of operations.

The commander's intent succinctly describes what constitutes success for the operation.

1-67. **Key tasks are those significant activities the force must perform as a whole to achieve the desired end state.** Key tasks are not specified tasks for any subordinate unit, but they may be sources of implied tasks. During execution—when significant opportunities present themselves or the concept of operations no longer fits the situation—subordinates use key tasks to focus their efforts on achieving the desired end state. Examples of key tasks include terrain the force must control or an effect the force must have on the enemy. Commanders include the purpose of each associated key task to facilitate subordinate decision making and disciplined initiative.

1-68. The end state is a set of desired future conditions the commander wants to exist when an operation ends. Commanders may describe the operation's end state by stating the desired conditions of the friendly force in relationship to desired conditions of the enemy, terrain, and civil considerations. A clearly defined end state promotes unity of effort among the force and with unified action partners.

1-69. A well-crafted commander's intent conveys a clear image of an operation's purpose and desired end state. The commander's intent provides a focus for subordinates to coordinate their separate efforts. Commanders personally prepare their commander's intent. When possible, they deliver it in person. Face-to-face delivery ensures shared understanding by allowing immediate clarification of specific points. Individuals can then exercise initiative within the overarching guidance of the commander's intent.

MISSION ORDERS

1-70. An order is a communication—verbal, written, or signaled—that conveys instructions from superiors to subordinates. The five-paragraph format (situation, mission, execution, sustainment, and command and signal) is the standard for issuing Army orders. Army commanders issue orders to give guidance, assign tasks, allocate resources, and delegate authority.

1-71. Mission command requires commanders to issue mission orders. **Mission orders are directives that emphasize to subordinates the results to be attained, not how they are to achieve them.** Mission orders enable subordinates to understand the situation, their commander's mission and intent, and their own tasks. Subordinate commanders decide how to accomplish their own mission. The commander's intent and concept of operations set guidelines that provide unity of effort while allowing subordinate commanders to exercise initiative in planning, preparing, and executing their operations.

Note. A mission order is not a separate type of order. It is a technique for writing orders that allows subordinates maximum freedom of action in accomplishing missions.

1-72. Staffs prepare clear, concise orders by using doctrinally correct military terms and symbols. Using the correct terms and symbols minimizes chances of misunderstanding and aids with brevity. Developing shorter plans helps maintain simplicity. Shorter plans are easier to disseminate, read, and remember.

1-73. Mission orders succinctly state the mission, task organization, commander's intent and concept of operations, tasks to subordinate units, and essential coordinating instructions. Tasks to subordinate units include all the standard elements (who, what, when, where, and why) with particular emphasis on the purpose (why). Mission orders are not an extended list of every task a unit may be required to accomplish. It never repeats items that are part of the standard operating procedures or that are commonly understood by the force. Mission orders do not contain directives to a subordinate that dictate how a task is to be accomplished. That is the province of the subordinate.

1-74. The proper level of detail in a mission order is situationally dependent. Some phases of operations require tighter control over subordinate elements than other phases. An air assault's air movement and landing phases, for example, require precise synchronization. Its ground maneuver plan requires less detail. As a rule, the base plan or order contains only the information required to synchronize combat power at the decisive time and place while allowing subordinates as much freedom of action as possible. Commanders rely on subordinates' initiative and coordination to act within the commander's intent and concept of operations.

Mission orders contain the proper level of detail in the context of a particular situation. They are neither so detailed that they stifle initiative nor so general that they provide insufficient direction.

1-75. Graphics that accompany mission orders are drawn in a manner that allows maximum flexibility during execution. They provide enough control for those activities requiring synchronization, but they avoid constraining subordinates' freedom of action within their assigned area. Ideally, graphics provide enough references such as checkpoints and phase lines for subordinate leaders to use them as a basis of shared understanding when deviation from the base order becomes necessary. Flexible graphics and mission orders together create conditions for initiative and rapid decision making.

1-76. Using mission orders does not mean commanders do not supervise subordinates during operations. Subordinates are accountable to their commanders for the use of delegated authority, but commanders remain solely responsible and accountable for the actions over which subordinates exercise delegated authority. Thus, commanders have the responsibility to check on their subordinates and provide directions and guidance as required to focus their activities. Commanders emphasize mission orders during training when actual consequences are low, allowing subordinates to develop their own solutions to problems and intervening only when necessary. This is valuable both for subordinates to gain experience in problem solving and confidence in exercising initiative and for commanders to develop an understanding of the capabilities of subordinates.

DISCIPLINED INITIATIVE

1-77. Disciplined initiative refers to the duty individual subordinates have to exercise initiative within the constraints of the commander's intent to achieve the desired end state. Simply put, disciplined initiative is when subordinates have the discipline to follow their orders and adhere to the plan until they realize that their orders and the plan are no longer suitable for the situation in which they find themselves. This may occur because enemy forces do something unforeseen, there is a new or more serious threat, or a golden opportunity emerges that offers a greater chance of success than the original course of action. The subordinate leader then takes action on their own initiative to adjust to the new situation and achieve their commander's intent, reporting to the commander about the new situation when able to do so.

1-78. Leaders and subordinates who exercise disciplined initiative create opportunities by taking action to develop a situation without asking for further guidance. Commanders rely on subordinates to act to meet their intent, not simply adhere to a plan that is no longer working. Under mission command, subordinates are required to exercise disciplined initiative in the absence of orders, when current orders no longer apply, or when an opportunity or threat presents itself. They, on their own responsibility, take actions that they think will best accomplish the mission when communication with higher echelons is intermittent or decisions must be made immediately.

1-79. A subordinate's initiative may be the starting point for seizing, retaining, and exploiting the operational initiative by forcing an enemy to respond to friendly action. *Operational initiative* is the setting of tempo and terms of action throughout an operation (ADP 3-0). The effect of multiple subordinates exercising disciplined initiative sets the conditions for friendly forces to seize the operational initiative in chaotic and ambiguous situations.

1-80. When exercising initiative, neither commanders nor subordinates are independent actors. Subordinates consider at least the following two factors when deciding when to exercise initiative:

- Whether the benefits of the action outweigh the risk of desynchronizing the overall operation.
- Whether the action will further the higher commander's intent.

1-81. The main consideration in exercising initiative is the urgency of the situation. If time permits, subordinates attempt to communicate their new situation and recommended course of action to their commander. Their commander then assesses the implications for the overall force, the impact on other operations, and whether subordinates require additional support. However, subordinates must depart from their orders when they are unable to contact their commander or when there is a limited amount of time to seize a fleeting opportunity. If doubt exists about whether to contact their commander or depart from orders and act to seize a fleeting opportunity, subordinates should act if they can do so within their commander's intent.

1-82. Fostering a command climate that encourages disciplined initiative requires commanders to accept risk and underwrite the good faith mistakes of subordinates in training, before the unit is committed to combat. Commanders set conditions for subordinates to learn and gain the experience they need to operate on their own. Subordinates learn to trust that they have the authority and responsibility to act, knowing their commander will back their decisions. Because mutual trust and shared understanding constitute the foundation of subordinate initiative, commanders train subordinates to act within the commander's intent in uncertain situations.

RISK ACCEPTANCE

1-83. *Risk* is the probability and severity driven chance of loss, caused by threat or other hazards (ATP 5-19). Commanders account for risk when evaluating the likelihood of mission success. Risk can be assessed through the cost imposed by, or the impact on, achievement of objectives.

1-84. Commanders analyze risk in collaboration with subordinates to determine what level of risk exists and how to mitigate it. When considering how much risk to accept with a course of action, commanders consider risk to the mission and risk to the force against the perceived benefit. They apply judgment regarding the importance of an objective, time available, and anticipated cost. Commanders balance the tension between protecting the force and accepting risks that must be taken to accomplish their mission.

There is no magic formula for quantification of risk. Staffs provide decision makers an assessment of the expected risks, costs, benefits, and potential consequences of proposed military actions. This facilitates decision makers to reduce, control, or accept risk.

1-85. The greatest opportunity may come from the course of action with the most risk. An example of this would be committing significant forces to a potentially costly attack to fix the bulk of enemy forces in place to set the conditions for their envelopment by other forces. Another would be taking a difficult but unexpected route to achieve surprise.

1-86. While each situation is different, commanders avoid undue caution or commitment of resources to guard against every perceived threat. Expecting to avoid all risk is unrealistic and detrimental to mission accomplishment. Waiting for perfect intelligence and synchronization may increase risk or close a window

of opportunity. Mission command requires that commanders and subordinates manage accepted risk, exercise initiative, and act decisively, even when the outcome is uncertain.

1-87. Reasonably estimating and intentionally accepting risk is not gambling. Gambling occurs when the commander risks the force without a reasonable level of information about the outcome. Therefore, commanders avoid gambles. Commanders carefully determine risks, analyze and minimize as many hazards as possible, and then accept risk to accomplish the mission. (Refer to ATP 5-19 for more information on the risk management process.)

THE ROLE OF SUBORDINATES IN MISSION COMMAND

1-88. The mission command approach to C2 requires active participation by personnel of all ranks and duty positions. Subordinate officers, noncommissioned officers, and Soldiers all have important roles in the exercise of mission command. During operations, subordinates are delegated authority through orders and standard operating procedures to make decisions within their commander's intent. Commanders expect subordinates to exercise this authority to further the commander's intent when changes in the situation render orders irrelevant, or when communications are lost with higher echelon headquarters.

Corporal Alvin York and Mission Command

On the morning of 8 October 1918, Soldiers of the 82nd Division began an attack to sever the German supply network in the Argonne Forest. Among the men in this push was Corporal Alvin York, a squad leader in the 328th Infantry Regiment.

Initially, the American attack seemed to go well as forward-deployed Germans seemingly retreated in the face of superior numbers. However, this was a ruse, as the Germans were falling back into prepared positions. Once the Americans were in the middle of the kill zone, the Germans opened fire. This was quickly followed by German artillery ripping gaping holes in the American line.

Among the first to fall was Corporal York's platoon leader, Lieutenant Kirby Stewart, and as the casualties mounted, the American attack quickly foundered. With Lieutenant Stewart dead, Sergeant Harry Parsons assumed command of Corporal York's platoon. After surveying the situation, he ordered Sergeant Bernard Early, Corporal York, Corporal Murray Savage, and Corporal William Cutting to advance with their squads to a defile to the south. From here, Sergeant Parsons surmised that they might be able to get behind the German lines and eliminate the machine guns that were holding up the advance.

After dodging German fire, Sergeant Early led his 16 men to the defilade, then up a cut in the valley that led behind the German positions. They slowly worked their way around the German infantry and subsequently surprised and captured some 70 German soldiers, including the battalion commander. While the Americans tried to line up their prisoners, a machine-gun crew on a nearby hill yelled to the captured Germans to take cover and then opened fire. The blast of bullets killed six Americans and wounded three. Corporal York was the highest-ranking Soldier not hit, and he took charge of the remaining seven men.

With the surviving Americans and German prisoners clinging to the ground, Corporal York seized the initiative. He charged up the hill, outflanked the German machine gun and an infantry platoon, killing 19. Seeing a large group of German reinforcements arriving from further up the hill, Corporal York went back to his men. As he came down the hill, he was spotted by a German officer who ordered a bayonet charge to kill the American. Seeing a platoon of Germans charging, Corporal York slid on his side, pulled out his 1911 Colt automatic pistol, and began picking off enemy soldiers from back to front. Seeing this, the previously captured German battalion commander slowly got up off of the ground and approached Corporal York. Standing behind Corporal York, he cautiously yelled above the din, "English?" Corporal York replied, "American!" In exasperation, the German commander answered, "Good Lord! If you won't shoot anymore, I will make them give up."

Corporal York and his men quickly organized their prisoners, which now numbered 100, into a formation and began marching them out of the forest. During the march back to the American lines, the Americans ended up walking into another group of Germans. Corporal York secured their surrender as well, increasing his prisoner count to 132. This saved his unit from destruction, thwarted a German counterattack, and allowed the 82nd Division to achieve its objective. For his heroism, Corporal York was promoted to sergeant, awarded the Medal of Honor, and would go down in history as America's most celebrated hero of the First World War.

1-89. Because mission command decentralizes decision making authority and grants subordinates significant freedom of action, it demands more of subordinates at all levels. Commanders train and educate subordinates so that they demonstrate good judgment when exercising initiative. Subordinates are competent in their respective fields, and they are confident they will have the commander's support to make and implement decisions. They embrace opportunities to assume responsibility for achieving the commander's intent.

1-90. Subordinates do not wait for a breakdown in communications or a crisis to learn how to act within the commander's intent. Subordinates look for every opportunity to demonstrate and exercise initiative. To the greatest extent possible, they report what they intend to do and then execute unless their commander specifically denies them permission. As subordinates realize their commander will support sound decisions, their trust in the Commander increases and they become more willing to exercise initiative. As commanders see subordinates perform in uncertain situations, they gain trust in their subordinates' judgment and ability.

COMMAND AND CONTROL WARFIGHTING FUNCTION OVERVIEW

1-91. A *warfighting function* is a group of tasks and systems united by a common purpose that commanders use to accomplish missions and training objectives (ADP 3-0). The purpose of warfighting functions is to provide an intellectual organization for common critical capabilities available to commanders and staffs at all echelons. The six Army warfighting functions are C2, movement and maneuver, intelligence, fires, sustainment, and protection. Each warfighting function complements and reinforces the other functions. Their integration and synchronization generate the combat power available for commanders to execute operations and accomplish missions. (Refer to ADP 3-0 for more information on the warfighting functions.)

1-92. The *command and control warfighting function* is the related tasks and a system that enable commanders to exercise authority and direction to accomplish missions (ADP 3-0). The exercise of authority and direction includes integrating forces and synchronizing the warfighting functions effectively into a concept of operations to achieve objectives and accomplish missions. The C2 warfighting function consists of the C2 warfighting function tasks and the C2 system.

1-93. The C2 warfighting function tasks focus on integrating the activities of the other warfighting functions to accomplish missions. Commanders, assisted by their staffs, integrate numerous processes and activities within their headquarters and across the force through the C2 warfighting function tasks. These tasks include the following:

- Command forces (See chapter 2).
- Control operations (See chapter 3).
- Organize and employ the C2 system (See chapter 4).

1-94. Commanders need support to effectively exercise C2. At every echelon of command, each commander employs a C2 system: the arrangement of people, processes, data and networks, and C2 nodes that enable commanders to conduct operations. The C2 system supports the commander's decision making, disseminates the commander's decisions to subordinates, and facilitates controlling forces. Commanders employ their C2 system to enable the people and formations conducting operations to work towards a common purpose. All equipment and procedures exist to achieve this end. Commanders organize the four components of their C2 system to support decision making and facilitate communication. The C2 system enables commanders to communicate with higher, adjacent, supporting, and subordinate commands to control all aspects of operations. (See chapter 4 for a detailed discussion of the C2 system.)

Commanders seek to improve their C2 system for operational advantage and adapt the system based on changing circumstances.

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Chapter 2

Command

This chapter discusses the nature and elements of command. It then describes the role of the commander in operations. The chapter concludes with a discussion of guides to effective command.

NATURE OF COMMAND

2-1. Command is the authority that a commander in the armed forces lawfully exercises over subordinates by virtue of rank or assignment. Command includes the authority and responsibility for effectively using available resources and for planning the employment of, organizing, directing, coordinating, and controlling military forces for the accomplishment of missions. It also includes responsibility for the health, welfare, morale, and discipline of assigned personnel.

2-2. Command is personal. In Army regulations and doctrine, an individual is given the authority to command, not an institution or group. The legal and ethical responsibilities of a commander exceed those of any other leader of similar rank who is serving in a staff position. The commander alone is responsible for what the command does or does not do.

2-3. Command is more art than science. It requires judgment and depends on actions only human beings can perform. The art of command comprises the creative and skillful exercise of authority through timely decision making and leadership. Commanders constantly use judgment gained from experience and training to delegate authority, make decisions, determine the appropriate degree of control, and allocate resources. Proficiency in the art of command stems from years of schooling, self-development, introspection, and operational and training experiences. It also requires a deep understanding of the science of war.

2-4. The basic techniques of command do not change between echelons. However, direct leadership within a command decreases as the level of command increases, and applying organizational leadership as described in ADP 6-22 becomes more relevant. Officers prepare for higher command by developing and exercising their skills when commanding at lower levels.

ELEMENTS OF COMMAND

2-5. The elements of command are authority, responsibility, decision making, and leadership. Authority is the right and power to judge, act, or command. Commanders are responsible for the actions, accomplishments, and failures of their subordinates, retaining overall accountability even when authority is delegated. Decision making is the process of applying judgment to select a course of action most favorable to accomplishing the mission. Leadership is the activity of influencing people by providing purpose, direction, and motivation to accomplish the mission and improve the organization.

AUTHORITY

2-6. Authority is the right and power to judge, act, or command. Legal authority to enforce orders under the law is a key aspect of command which distinguishes military commanders from staff officers and civilian leaders. Commanders understand that operations affect, and are affected by, human interactions. As such, they seek to establish personal authority. A commander's personal authority reinforces that commander's legal authority. Personal authority ultimately arises from the actions of commanders and the resulting trust and confidence generated by these actions. Commanders earn respect and trust by upholding laws, adhering to the Army ethic, applying Army leadership principles, and demonstrating tactical and technical expertise.

2-7. Commanders may delegate authority to subordinates to accomplish a mission or assist in fulfilling their responsibilities. This includes delegating authority to members of their staff. Delegation allows subordinates to decide and act for their commander in specified areas. When delegating authority, commanders remain accountable for mission accomplishment, for the lives and care of their Soldiers, and for effectively using Army resources. Therefore, commanders use judgment in determining how much authority to delegate.

Assuming Command: General Ridgway Takes Eighth Army

After secretly crossing the Yalu River in mid-October 1950, the Chinese 13th Army Group launched its first offensive against United Nations forces on 25 October. By the end of November, the 13th Army Group had pushed most of the Eighth U.S. Army out of northwest Korea. By mid-December, the Eighth Army had retreated south of the 38th Parallel. To add to the United Nations forces' troubles, the Eighth Army commander, General Walton Walker, was killed in a jeep accident on 23 December.

Then Deputy Chief of Staff for Operations, General Matthew Ridgway, recalls the phone call he received from the Army Chief of Staff, General Joe Collins. "Matt," he said, "I'm sorry to tell you that Johnny Walker has been killed in a jeep accident in Korea. I want you to get your things together and get out there just as soon as you can."

In his book, *Soldier: The Memoirs of Matthew B. Ridgway*, General Ridgway describes his initial thoughts on assuming command of the Eighth Army:

"Quickly I ran over in my mind all that I knew of the situation. As Deputy Chief of Staff for Operations, the map of Korea had become as familiar to me as the lines in my hand. I knew our strength, and our weakness. I knew personally all the top commanders in Eighth Army, except General Oliver Smith of the 1st Marine Division, and from what I knew of him, I knew I could depend on him implicitly.

Armed with this background knowledge, what should I do? Quickly, a pattern of action took place in my mind. First, of course, I would report to General MacArthur, and receive from him his estimate of the situation and broad general directives concerning operations. Next, I would assume command-and this, I knew, must be done in one simple, brief, sincere statement which would convey to Eighth Army my supreme confidence that it could turn and face and fight and defeat the Chinese horde that had sprung so suddenly from beyond the Yalu. Once this was done, I would meet with Eighth Army staff and get from them their appraisal of the situation. After that, I would call on every commander in his battle area, look into his face and the faces of his men, and form my own opinion of his firmness and resolution-or the lack thereof. Once these things were done, then I could begin to plan, could make the big decision whether to stand and hold, or to attack."

Under General Ridgway's leadership, the Chinese offensive was slowed and finally brought to a halt at the battles of Chip'yong-ni and Wonju. He then led his troops in OPERATION THUNDERBOLT, a counter-offensive in early 1951.

RESPONSIBILITY

2-8. Commanders are legally and ethically responsible for the decisions they make or do not make, and for the actions, accomplishments, and failures of their subordinates. Commanders may delegate authority, but they still retain overall accountability for the actions of their commands.

2-9. Command responsibilities include mission accomplishment; the health, welfare, morale, and discipline of Soldiers; and the use and maintenance of resources. In most cases, these responsibilities do not conflict. However, the responsibility for mission accomplishment sometimes conflicts with the responsibility for Soldiers or the stewardship of resources. The importance of the mission informs commanders how much risk to Soldiers and equipment to accept. When there is conflict among the three, mission accomplishment comes before Soldiers, and Soldiers come before concerns for resources. Commanders try to keep such conflicts to an absolute minimum.

DECISION MAKING

2-10. Commanders exercise their authority in part by making decisions and directing action. Decision making involves applying both the art and science of war. Many aspects of military operations—movement rates, fuels consumption, and weapons effects—can be reduced to numbers, calculations, and tables. They belong to the science of war and are important to understanding what is possible with the resources available. Other aspects—the impact of leadership, complexity of operations, and uncertainty about the enemy—belong to the art of war. Successful commanders focus the most attention on those aspects belonging to the art of war.

2-11. For Army forces, decision making focuses on selecting a course of action that is most favorable to accomplishing the mission. Decision making can be deliberate, using the military decision-making process and a full staff, or decision making can be done very quickly by the commander alone. A commander's decisions ultimately guide the actions of the force.

2-12. Decision making requires knowing if, when, and what to decide as well as understanding the consequences of that decision. Critical to decision making is the ability to make decisions without perfect information, knowing when enough information allows acceptable decisions, and the willingness to act on imperfect information. Striking the balance between acting now with imperfect information and acting later with better information is essential to the art of command. Effective decision making includes—

- Developing and maintaining situational understanding.
- Applying critical and creative thinking.
- Determining the appropriate decision-making approach.
- Applying judgment to make informed choices.

Situational Understanding

2-13. Success in operations demands timely and effective decisions based on applying judgment to available information and knowledge. As such, commanders and staffs seek to build and maintain situational understanding throughout an operation. ***Situational understanding is the product of applying analysis and judgment to relevant information to determine the relationships among the operational and mission variables.*** Situational understanding allows commanders to make effective decisions and regulate the actions of their force with plans appropriate for the situation. It enables commanders and staffs to assess operations accurately. Commanders and staffs strive to maintain their situational understanding and work through periods of reduced understanding as a situation evolves. Effective commanders accept that uncertainty can never be eliminated, and they train subordinates to function in uncertain environments. (See Chapter 3 for more information on the operational and mission variables.)

2-14. Data orchestration, data analytics, and knowledge management assist commanders with analyzing to help build and maintain their situational understanding. There are four levels of meaning within the cognitive hierarchy. All levels include data, information, knowledge, and understanding. At the lowest level, processing transforms data into information. Analysis then refines information into knowledge. Commanders and staffs then apply judgment to transform knowledge into understanding. How commanders and staff add meaning to data into understanding can be visualized as a hierarchy as shown in Figure 2-1 on page 22.

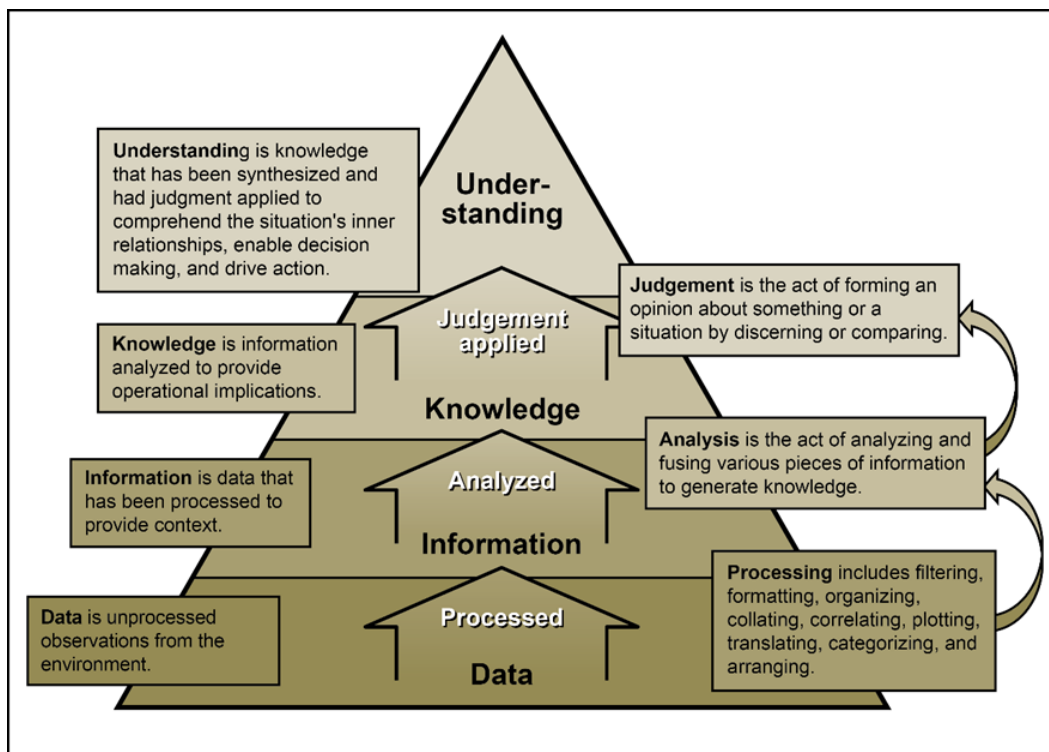


Figure 2-1. Cognitive Hierarchy

2-15. **Data is unprocessed figures, signals, or observations from the environment (physical and virtual) that can be transmitted or processed to improve situational understanding.** Subordinate units push data to inform higher headquarters of events that facilitate situational understanding. Higher units push data to provide guidance and direct action. Data can be quantified, stored, and organized in files and databases. However, data only becomes useful when processed into information.

2-16. **Information is, in the context of decision making, data that has been organized and processed in order to provide context for further analysis.** The amount of information available makes managing information and using it to make effective decisions critical to success during operations. Commanders and staffs apply experience and judgment to information to gain shared understanding of events and conditions in which they make decisions during operations. Effective C2 requires information to be further developed into knowledge for commanders to achieve understanding.

2-17. **Knowledge is, in the context of decision making, information that has been analyzed and evaluated for operational implications.** It is also comprehension gained through study, experience, practice, and human interaction that provides the basis for expertise and skilled judgment. In the context of decision making, there are two types of knowledge: tacit knowledge and explicit knowledge.

2-18. Tacit knowledge resides in an individual's mind. It is the purview of individuals, not technology. All individuals have a unique store of knowledge gained from experience, training, and other people. This knowledge includes an appreciation for nuances, subtleties, and workarounds. Intuition, mental agility, effective responses to crises, and the ability to adapt are forms of tacit knowledge. Leaders use tacit knowledge, their own and that of their subordinates, to solve complex problems and make decisions.

2-19. Explicit knowledge consists of information that can be organized, applied, and transferred using digital (such as computer files) or non-digital (such as paper) means. Explicit knowledge lends itself to rules, limits, and precise meanings. Examples of explicit knowledge include doctrinal publications, orders, and databases. Explicit knowledge is primarily used to support situational awareness and shared understanding as it applies to decision making.

2-20. **Understanding is, in the context of decision making, knowledge that has been synthesized and had judgment applied to comprehend the situation's inner relationships, enable decision making, and drive action.** Understanding is judgment applied to knowledge in the context of a particular situation. Understanding is knowing enough about the situation to change it by applying action. Judgment is based on experience, expertise, and intuition. Ideally, true understanding is the basis for decisions. However, uncertainty and time often make achieving perfect understanding before deciding and acting unlikely. (See Chapter 3 for more information on knowledge management and information management.)

Critical and Creative Thinking

2-21. Thinking critically and creatively aids effective decision making. Critical thinking is purposeful and reflective thought about what to believe or what to do in response to observations, experience, verbal or written expressions, or arguments. Critical thinking involves questioning information, assumptions, conclusions, and points of view to interpret data and information, evaluate evidence, and clarify goals. Critical thinking helps commanders and staffs understand situations, identify causes of problems, arrive at justifiable conclusions, and make good judgments.

By thinking critically, commanders judge whether the information they encounter is true, false, or somewhere along a scale of plausibility between true or false.

2-22. Creative thinking involves thinking in innovative ways using imagination, insight, and different ideas. Commanders and leaders often face both new problems and old problems that require new solutions. Even familiar situations require creative solutions, since an enemy force will adapt to past friendly approaches. Leaders look at different options to solve problems using lessons from similar circumstances in the past and innovative approaches that come from new ideas. Creatively combining old and new ideas can create difficult dilemmas for an enemy force. (Refer to ATP 5-0.1 for more information on critical and creative thinking, including biases and logic flaws to avoid.)

Approaches To Decision Making

2-23. Generally, there are two decision making approaches commanders use based on the situation. These approaches are analytic and intuitive decision making. Analytic decision making provides commanders with the most relevant information by employing systematic analysis of data. Through intuitive decision making, commanders rely on their intuition to make decisions. Whether the commander relies on analytics or intuition, the responsibility for the decision rests with them, not the analytic tools. Effective commanders consider their own experiences, the experiences of their staff, and the available time and information when determining the most suitable decision-making approach.

2-24. Commanders switch between and combine intuitive and analytical decision-making techniques as the situation requires. Because uncertainty and the tempo of large-scale combat operations drive most decisions, commanders emphasize intuitive decision making and develop their subordinates accordingly. However, when time is available and depending on the operational context of a situation, commanders and staffs use the military decision-making process or Army design methodology during planning.

Analytic Decision Making

2-25. Analytic decision making generates several solutions, compares those solutions to a set of criteria, and selects the best course of action. It aims to produce the optimal solution by comparing multiple options. It emphasizes analytic reasoning guided by experience, and commanders use it when time is available. This approach offers several advantages. Analytic decision making—

- Allows the methodical breakdown of tasks into recognizable elements.
- Ensures commanders consider, analyze, and evaluate relevant factors and employ techniques such as war-gaming.
- Provides a systematic approach when a decision involves processing large amounts of data and information.
- Gives inexperienced personnel a logically structured approach.

2-26. The challenges of traditional analytic decision making highlight the need for tools and methods that enhance analysis, efficiency, and effectiveness in dynamic environments. Decision optimization, which applies data and advanced analytics—including software and artificial intelligence—improves operational processes and outcomes. Data analytics provides a structured approach to processing and interpreting vast amounts of data, enabling commanders and staffs to make timely, informed decisions. (See Chapter 3 for more on data analytics and the four levels of data analysis.)

Analytic decision making is not appropriate for all situations, especially during execution, when forces must adapt to rapidly changing situations.

2-27. Artificial intelligence, as a key tool of decision optimization, provides the commander with often unparalleled access to analysis. To use these tools effectively, commanders craft questions as nuanced as their own intent, are cognizant of how the tools were developed, and evaluate the data used for training artificial intelligence models. Distortions in training artificial intelligence models can cause biases in the recommendations presented. Commanders must understand both the capabilities and limitations of these tools.

Intuitive Decision Making

2-28. Intuitive decision making involves pattern recognition based on knowledge, judgment, experience, education, intelligence, boldness, perception, and character. Intuitive decision making—

- Focuses on assessing the situation more than on comparing multiple options.
- Results in an acceptable course of action instead of the optimal course of action derived from an analytical approach.
- Is more effective when time is short.
- Relies on a commander's experience and ability to recognize the key elements and implications of a particular problem or situation.
- Focuses on the larger picture more than on individual components.

2-29. Intuitive decision making is faster than analytic decision making, but it requires an adequate level of experience to recognize an acceptable course of action. There is a difference between sound intuition and uninformed assumptions. When using intuitive decision making, leaders are aware of their own biases and the differences between their current operational environment and those they experienced in the past.

2-30. By emphasizing experienced judgment over deliberate analysis, commanders increase tempo and retain flexibility to deal with uncertainty. The intuitive approach is consistent with the fact that there are no perfect solutions to operational challenges. Even when making intuitive decisions, commanders may have time to employ more analytic techniques. Time permitting, commanders use their staff to validate intuitive decisions to ensure they are feasible, acceptable, and suitable.

2-31. In practice, the two approaches are rarely mutually exclusive. When time is not critical, commanders use an analytical approach or incorporate analysis into their intuitive decisions. Commanders blend intuitive and analytic decision making to remain objective and make timely, effective decisions. Commanders seek as much analysis as possible within the time available. In situations requiring immediate decisions, this analysis may be no more than the commander's own rapid mental development, analysis, and selection of a course of action—which may appear completely intuitive. Combining both approaches best accounts for the many factors that affect decisions. An approach that combines analytic and intuitive decision making is the rapid decision making and synchronization process found in FM 5-0.

Judgment

2-32. Commanders make decisions using judgment acquired from experience, training, and study. Experience contributes to judgment by providing a basis for rapidly identifying practical courses of action and dismissing impractical ones. Commanders use judgment to assess information, situations, or circumstances shrewdly and draw feasible conclusions. Skilled judgment helps commanders make sound decisions.

2-33. Judgment is required for selecting the time and place to act. Commanders act by assigning missions, prioritizing, managing risk, allocating resources, and leading. A thorough knowledge of warfare, a strong

ethical sense, and an understanding of enemy and friendly capabilities form the basis of the judgment commanders require.

2-34. Judgment becomes more refined as commanders become more experienced. Increasing their knowledge, developing their intellect, and gaining experience allows commanders to develop the greater judgment required for increased responsibilities. As part of decision-making, commanders apply their judgment to—

- Identify, mitigate, and accept risk.
- Delegate authority.
- Prioritize resources.
- Direct their staff.

Identify, Mitigate, and Accept Risk

2-35. Commanders use judgment when identifying risk by deciding how much risk to accept, mitigating risk where possible, and managing the risk they must accept. They accept risk when seizing opportunities. They reduce risk with foresight and planning, while regularly examining any assumptions associated with previous risk-related decisions.

Risks result from enemy action, incorrect assumptions, limited resources, lack of preparation, friendly force activities, and environment and terrain.

2-36. Consideration of risk begins during planning, as commanders and staffs assess risk for each course of action and propose control measures. Planners provide commanders an assessment of the expected risks, costs, benefits, and potential consequences of proposed military actions. This facilitates decisions to reduce, control, or accept risk through a shared knowledge of potential consequences.

2-37. Commanders continuously assess how risk may be accumulating over time as operations progress, both at their own echelon as well as for their subordinates. Changes in the nature of an operation, the number and types of tasks assigned, available combat power, or changes in the threat may change the level of risk subordinates mitigate and accept. A series of discrete decisions about seemingly unrelated issues can, over time, change the level of risk in ways that are not readily apparent to a commander. However, these cumulative risks may be understood by one or more subordinates directly impacted by changing conditions or new decisions. It is therefore critical that commanders clearly communicate risk concerns to higher and lower echelons to ensure shared understanding and informed decision making.

2-38. Assumptions made during planning may change or compound over time, raising the level of risk. Risks that were acceptable in one context and based on one set of assumptions may be unacceptable when the context of the operation changes. In some instances, the situation changes to the point that a commander needs to adjust the level of risk subordinate commanders are required to take when the potential benefit no longer outweighs the likely cost. For example, a unit performing in an economy of force role with a particular task organization may be directed to detach additional units to support other efforts to the point where it can no longer effectively accomplish its mission. The higher-level commander is unlikely to have sufficient situational awareness to understand precisely when the threshold of acceptable risk for mission accomplishment has been crossed without a continuous dialogue with that subordinate commander. It is as much the responsibility of the subordinate to keep higher echelons informed as it is the responsibility of the higher-level commander to seek risk analysis from the subordinate.

2-39. Instilling risk acceptance goes hand in hand with creating an environment where subordinates are encouraged to accept risk and underwrite the good faith mistakes of subordinates in training. Commanders realize that subordinates may not accomplish all tasks initially and that errors may occur. Commanders train subordinates to act within the commander's intent in uncertain situations. Commanders give subordinates the latitude to make mistakes and learn.

2-40. During training, commanders might allow subordinates to execute an excessively risky decision, keeping the safety of Soldiers in mind, as a teaching point. They then instruct subordinates afterward on how to determine a more appropriate level of risk. This sort of coaching helps commanders gain trust in their subordinates' judgment and initiative, and it builds subordinates' trust in their commander. During operations, commanders may need to intervene when a subordinate accepts risk that exceeds the benefits expected.

Risk Acceptance: OPERATION HAWTHORN, Dak To, Vietnam

At 0230, on 7 June 1966, a battalion of the 24th North Vietnamese Army (NVA) Regiment attacked an artillery firebase manned by elements of 1st Brigade, 101st Airborne Division, beginning the battle of Dak To. While the forces at the firebase defeated this attack, two battalions of the 101st Airborne were lifted in by helicopters to envelop the 24th NVA Regiment in the Dak To area. One battalion, 1/327th, attacked north up Dak Tan Kan valley, while the other, 2/502d, attacked toward the south. The 1/327th encountered the NVA first and fixed them. The 2/502d established a blocking position initially but then began a sweep south to link up with 1/327th.

The 2/502d used its famous "checkerboard" technique in its advance, breaking down into small units, with squad-size patrols searching designated areas into which the battalion had divided its area of operations. This technique covered ground, but the squads were too weak to face stiff opposition. Company commanders had to assess indicators, decide when they indicated the presence of heavy enemy forces, and assemble their companies for action. As C Company advanced on 12 June, its commander, Captain William Carpenter Jr., sensed those indicators and concentrated his company, but it was surrounded and in danger of being overrun by an estimated NVA battalion. As he spoke to his battalion commander, Lieutenant Colonel Hank Emerson ("the Gunfighter"), the sounds of the charging enemy could be heard over the radio. Captain Carpenter reportedly called for an air strike "right on top of us." The only air support available was armed with napalm; when it hit, it broke the enemy attack and saved the company. A day later, another company linked up with C Company, and they continued the mission. The battle of Dak To was a staggering defeat for the NVA. Captain Carpenter's action can be considered a necessary risk. The survival of his force was at stake. The NVA would have destroyed C Company before another company could relieve it.

Captain Carpenter later stated privately that he realized the survival of his company was at stake, but that he did not actually call the air strike directly in on his position. Instead, he told the forward air controller to use the smoke marking his company's position as the aiming point for the air strike. He knew that using conventional air strike techniques and safe distances would not defeat the enemy. He also reasoned that the napalm would "splash" forward of his position, causing more enemy than friendly casualties. The air strike did just that. Thus, Captain Carpenter exercised judgment based on experience. Captain Carpenter believed he was taking a high risk from the standpoint of troop safety. But he accepted that risk, made a decision, and acted. His actions saved his company and contributed to a major NVA defeat. Captain Carpenter and his first sergeant, First Sergeant Walter Sabaulski, received the Distinguished Service Cross for their heroism.

Delegate Authority

2-41. Commanders use judgment to determine how much authority to delegate to subordinates and how much they can decentralize execution. Commanders delegate authority and set the level of their personal oversight of delegated tasks based on their assessment of the skill and experience of their subordinates. Ideally, once commanders delegate authority, they supervise to the minimum level required to ensure their subordinates' and the mission's success. When delegating authority to subordinates, commanders do everything in their power to set conditions for their success. Commanders allocate sufficient resources to their subordinates so their subordinates can accomplish their missions. Resources include people, units, services, supplies, equipment,

Under the mission command approach, delegated authority is proportional to the commanders' trust in the abilities of their subordinates.

networks, information, and time. Commanders allocate resources through task organization and established priorities of support.

2-42. Commanders delegate authority verbally, in writing, or by a combination of the two methods. Examples of delegated authority include authority over an area of expertise or technical specialty, a geographic area, or specific kinds of actions. Commanders may limit delegated authority in time, or they may use an enduring approach. Commanders ensure members of the command, especially the staff and subordinate commanders, understand to whom and what authorities have been delegated. Delegation not only applies to subordinate commanders but also to members of the staff. (Refer to FM 5-0 for an example of a delegated authorities matrix.)

Prioritize Resources

2-43. Commanders allocate resources to accomplish the mission. Allocating resources requires judgment because resources can be limited. Considerations for prioritizing resources include how to—

- Accomplish the mission effectively.
- Protect the lives of Soldiers.
- Apply the principles of mass and economy of force.
- Posture their force for subsequent operations.

2-44. The primary consideration for allocating resources is how their use contributes to effective mission accomplishment. Commanders do not determine how to accomplish a mission based on conserving resources or giving all subordinates an equal share. Instead, they allocate resources efficiently to ensure effectiveness. The objective—to accomplish the mission—guides every element of operations. A plan that does not accomplish the mission, regardless of how well it conserves resources, is not effective.

2-45. The next priority is to protect the lives of Soldiers. Commanders determine how to protect the lives of Soldiers before considering how to conserve material resources. They use material resources generously to save lives. If there are different but equally effective ways to accomplish the mission, a commander considers ways which use fewer resources.

2-46. The third aspect of resource allocation is based on two of the principles of war—mass and economy of force. The principle of mass means that commanders weight the main effort with the greatest possible combat power to overwhelm an enemy force and ensure mission accomplishment. Economy of force refers to allocating the minimum essential combat power to all supporting efforts. Supporting efforts typically receive fewer resources than the main effort. Commanders accept risk in supporting efforts to give weight to the main effort.

2-47. When allocating resources, commanders consider the cost to the force and the effects of the current operation on the ability to execute follow-on operations. If subordinates believe they have not received adequate resources, or they believe accomplishing their mission would produce an unacceptable cost to the force, they inform their commander. The commander then decides whether to accept risk, allocate more resources, or change the plan.

Commanders determine the amount of combat power essential to each task and allocate sufficient resources to accomplish it.

2-48. The fourth aspect of applying judgment to resource allocation concerns posturing the force for further operations. Commanders balance immediate mission accomplishment with resource requirements for subsequent operations. Commanders accomplish their missions at the least cost to the force, so they do not impair its ability to conduct follow-on operations. They visualize short-term and long-term effects of their resource use and determine priorities. At lower echelons, commanders focus more on the immediate operation—the short term. At progressively higher echelons, commanders give more consideration to long-term operations.

Direct their Staff

2-49. Commanders rely on and expect initiative from their staff members as much as from subordinate commanders. Delegating authority allows commanders to use their time for the more creative aspects of command. Commanders delegate authority and set the level of their personal involvement in staff activities

based on their assessment of the skill and experience of their subordinates. This assessment requires skilled judgment.

2-50. Within their headquarters, commanders apply judgment to determine when to intervene and participate personally in staff operations and when to let their staff operate on their own based on guidance. Commanders cannot do everything themselves or make every decision; such participation does not give their staff the experience mission command requires. However, commanders cannot simply approve staff products produced without their input. Commanders supervise staff work where it is necessary. They use their situational understanding and commander's visualization to provide guidance from which their staff produce plans and orders. In deciding when and where to interact with subordinates, commanders determine where they can best use their limited time to the greatest effect.

LEADERSHIP

2-51. *Leadership* is the activity of influencing people by providing purpose, direction, and motivation to accomplish the mission and improve the organization (ADP 6-22). Leadership involves taking responsibility for decisions, being loyal to subordinates, and establishing a team that produces success. It involves inspiring and directing assigned forces toward a purposeful end, managing resources, demonstrating moral and physical courage in the face of adversity, and providing the vision that both focuses and anticipates the future course of events. (Refer to ADP 6-22 for more information on Army Leadership.)

Professional competence, personality, and the will of strong commanders represent a significant part of any unit's combat power.

2-52. While leadership requirements differ with unit size and type, all leaders demonstrate character and ethical standards. Leaders know and understand their subordinates. They act with courage and conviction in battle. Leaders build trust and teamwork. During operations, they know where to be to make decisions or to influence the action by their personal presence.

2-53. Commanders recognize that military operations take a toll on the moral, physical, and mental stamina of the Soldiers making up their formations. They understand that experience, interpersonal relationships, and the environment influence the people conducting operations. Leaders account for these factors when motivating people to accomplish tasks in the face of danger and hardship. Setting a good personal example is critical to effective leadership.

2-54. Commanders are both leaders and followers. Being a responsible subordinate is part of being a good leader. Responsible subordinates support the chain of command and ensure their command supports the larger organization and its purpose. Successful commanders recognize the responsibilities they and their subordinates have to the next higher echelon and the larger formation overall.

2-55. Commanders know the status of their forces. Command sergeants major, first sergeants, and platoon sergeants play vital roles in providing commanders awareness about the morale and physical condition of their Soldiers. Commanders need to know when circumstances may prevent friendly forces from performing to their full potential. For example, a subordinate unit may have recently received inexperienced replacements, may have lost cohesion due to leader casualties, or may be extremely fatigued due to an extended period of operations.

2-56. Commanders press the fight tenaciously and aggressively. They accept risks and push Soldiers to the limits of their endurance for as long as possible to retain the operational initiative. They act aggressively to exploit fleeting opportunities. Effective commanders recognize when to push Soldiers to their limits and when to let them rest to prevent individual and collective collapse. Even the most successful combat actions can render units incapable of further operations.

2-57. Leadership is an important component of mitigating the effects of stress. Stress is an integral part of military service in general and in combat operations in particular. Leaders learn to mitigate stress for their subordinates and cope with it themselves. Two aspects of leadership that are unique to command are command presence and the location of the commander.

Command Presence

2-58. Command presence is the influence commanders have on those around them through their personal demeanor, appearance, and conduct. It requires contact with others, both physically and through voice C2 systems. Establishing command presence makes the commander's knowledge and experience available to subordinates and provides encouragement. It allows commanders to assess intangibles like morale and provide direct feedback on subordinate performance. Skilled commanders communicate tactical and technical knowledge that goes beyond plans and procedures. Command presence establishes a background for all plans and procedures so that subordinates can understand how and when to adapt them to achieve the commander's intent. Commanders can establish command presence in a variety of ways, including—

Commanders use their presence to gather and share information and assess operations through personal interaction with subordinates.

- Being seen and heard.
- Sharing risk and hardship.
- Setting a good personal example.
- Ensuring their commander's intent is widely understood.
- Providing clear face-to-face commander's guidance.
- Backbriefs and rehearsals.

2-59. Directly engaging subordinates and staffs allows commanders to motivate, build trust and confidence, exchange information, and assess the human aspects of operations. It allows commanders to assess the morale and stamina of subordinate units. Commanders use their presence to overcome uncertainty and chaos and maintain the focus of their forces. They adjust their communication style to fit the situation and the audience. They communicate both formally and informally; through questions, discussions, and conversations; and by both direct and indirect communication. Commanders position themselves where they can best command without losing the ability to respond to changing situations.

Location of the Commander

2-60. One of the fundamental dilemmas facing all commanders is where to position themselves during operations. As far as conditions allow, commanders should be forward where they can be seen and heard to best influence the main effort. Commanding forward allows commanders to assess the state of operations face-to-face with their subordinates and achieve shared understanding. It allows them to gather as much information as possible about actual combat conditions when making decisions. However, commanding forward does not mean taking over a subordinate's responsibilities.

2-61. Commanders consider their position in relation to both the forces they command and the mission. Their location can have important consequences, not only for the command but also for executing operations. The C2 system helps commanders position themselves forward without losing access to available information and analysis.

2-62. In larger tactical- and operational-level commands, C2 nodes are normally the focus of information flow and planning. However, commanders cannot always visualize the battlefield to direct and synchronize operations. Commanders often assess the situation up front, face-to-face with subordinate commanders and their units. Commanders employ their C2 system to position themselves wherever they can best command without losing the situational understanding that enables them to respond to opportunities and changing circumstances. The C2 system allows commanders to obtain the information they need to assess operations and risks, and make necessary adjustments, from anywhere in an area of operations.

2-63. Commanders might not always be where the critical action is occurring. This probability reinforces the necessity of training subordinates to operate using the mission command approach. Commanders then rely on subordinates to restore or exploit the situation without their presence or personal intervention.

2-64. Being physically present allows a commander to assess a much broader set of indicators of the unit's condition. Commanders gain firsthand appreciation for the human aspects of a situation that can rarely be gained any other way. They avoid the delays and distortions that occur as information travels down and up the chain of command. Finally, by their presence, commanders direct emphasis to critical spots and focus efforts on them. Some of the factors that influence a commander's location include—

- The need to understand the situation.
- The need to make decisions.
- The need to communicate.
- The need to motivate subordinates.

Where a commander is located can bring the leadership element of combat power directly to an operation, especially when that location allows for personal presence and the ability to directly observe events.

2-65. The commander's forward presence demonstrates a willingness to share danger and hardship. It also allows commanders to appraise for themselves a subordinate unit's condition, including its leaders' and Soldiers' morale. Forward presence allows commanders to sense the human aspects of conflict, particularly when fear and fatigue reduce effectiveness.

2-66. Commanders cannot let the perceived advantages of improved information technology compromise their obligation to personally lead by example. Face-to-face discussions and forward presence allow commanders to see things that may not be conveyed by the C2 system.

THE ROLE OF COMMANDERS IN OPERATIONS

2-67. Where mission command is the Army's approach to C2, the operations process is the framework for putting C2 into action. Commanders, staffs, and subordinate headquarters employ the operations process to organize efforts, integrate the warfighting functions across multiple domains, and synchronize forces to accomplish missions. (Refer to ADP 5-0 for more details on conducting the operations process.)

2-68. Commanders are the most important participants in the operations process. While staffs perform essential functions that amplify the effectiveness of operations, commanders drive the operations process through understanding, visualizing, describing, directing, leading, and assessing operations as shown in Figure 2-2. Accurate and timely running estimates maintained by staffs assist commanders in understanding the situation and making decisions throughout the operations process.

2-69. A commander's focus on understanding, visualizing, describing, directing, leading, and assessing throughout operations varies during different operations process activities. For example, during planning commanders focus more on understanding, visualizing, and describing. During execution, commanders often focus more on directing, leading, and assessing—while improving their situational understanding and modifying their visualization as needed. (Refer to ADP 5-0 for a detailed discussion on assessing operations.)

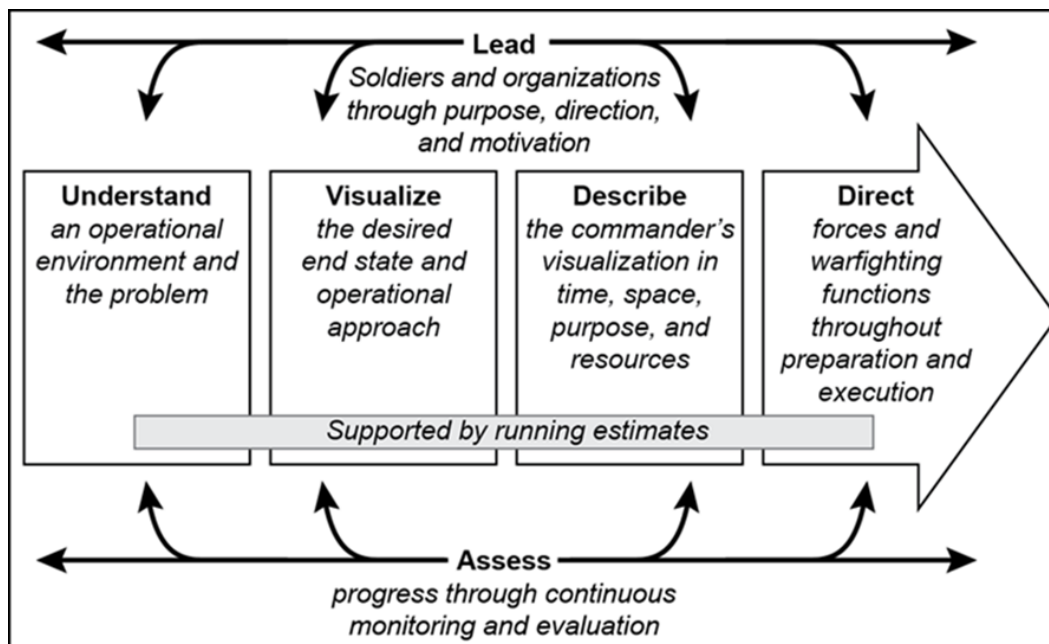


Figure 2-2. The Commander's Role in the Operations Process.

UNDERSTAND

2-70. To understand something is to grasp its nature and significance. Understanding includes establishing context—the set of circumstances that surround a particular event or situation. Understanding an operational environment and its associated problems is fundamental to establishing a situation's context and visualizing operations. An *operational environment* is the aggregate of the conditions, circumstances, and influences that affect the employment of capabilities and bear on the decisions of the commander (JP 3-0). For Army forces, an operational environment includes portions of each of the five domains (land, maritime, air, space, and cyberspace) understood through three dimensions (human, physical, and information). (Refer to FM 3-0 for a detailed discussion on an operational environment.)

2-71. Part of understanding an operational environment includes identifying and understanding problems. In the context of operations, an operational problem is a discrepancy between the current state of an operational environment and the desired end state. An operational problem includes those issues that impede commanders from accomplishing missions, achieving objectives, and attaining the desired end state.

2-72. Commanders collaborate with their staff, other commanders, and unified action partners to build a shared understanding of their operational environment and associated problems. Planning, intelligence preparation of the operational environment, and running estimates help commanders develop an initial understanding of their operational environment. Commanders direct reconnaissance and develop the situation to improve their understanding. Commanders circulate within the area of operations as often as possible, collaborating with subordinate commanders and speaking with Soldiers. Using personal observations and input from others (including running estimates from their staff), commanders improve their understanding of their operational environment throughout the operations process. Ideally, perfect understanding is the basis for decisions. However, commanders realize that uncertainty and time preclude achieving perfect understanding before deciding and acting.

VISUALIZE

2-73. As commanders begin to understand their operational environment, they start visualizing a desired end state and potential solutions to identified problems. Collectively, this is known as **commander's visualization—the mental process of developing situational understanding, determining a desired end state, and envisioning an operational approach by which the force will achieve that end state**. Figure 2-3 on page 32 depicts activities associated with developing the commander's visualization.

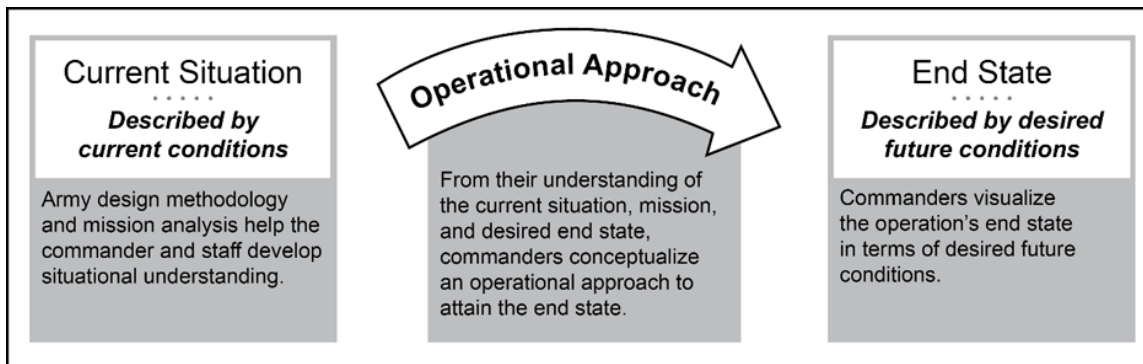


Figure 2-3. Commander's Visualization

2-74. In building their visualization, commanders first seek to understand those conditions that represent the current situation. Next, commanders envision a set of desired future conditions that represent the operation's end state. Commanders complete their visualization by conceptualizing an *operational approach*—a broad description of the mission, operational concepts, tasks, and actions required to accomplish the mission (JP 5-0).

DESCRIBE

2-75. Commanders describe their visualization to their staff and subordinate commanders to facilitate shared understanding and purpose throughout the force. During planning, commanders ensure subordinate commanders understand their visualization well enough to begin course of action development. During execution, commanders describe modifications to their visualization in updated planning guidance and directives. Commanders describe their visualization in doctrinal terms, refining and clarifying it as circumstances require. Commanders describe their visualization in terms of—

- Commander's intent (See chapter 1).
- Planning guidance, including an operational approach.
- Commander's critical information requirements (CCIRs).
- Essential elements of friendly information.

Commander's Planning Guidance

2-76. Commanders provide planning guidance to their staff based upon their visualization. Planning guidance conveys the essence of the commander's visualization, including a description of the operational approach. Effective planning guidance reflects how the commander sees the operation unfolding. The commander's planning guidance broadly describes when, where, and how the commander intends to employ combat power to accomplish the mission. Broad and general guidance gives staff and subordinate leaders maximum latitude; it enables proficient staffs to develop flexible and effective options. Commanders revise planning guidance based on staff and subordinate input and changing conditions during the operations process. (Refer to FM 5-0 for examples of planning guidance.)

Commander's Critical Information Requirements

2-77. Commanders describe gaps in their visualization by identifying their CCIRs. A *commander's critical information requirement* is specific information identified by the commander as being essential to facilitate timely decision making (JP 3-0). A CCIR is directly tied to a decision and establishes a reporting requirement. Commanders decide to designate an information requirement as a CCIR based on likely decisions and their visualization of the operation. A CCIR may support one or more decisions. During planning, staffs recommend information requirements for commanders to designate as CCIRs. Refinement of CCIRs is continuous throughout an operation. During preparation and execution, staffs recommend changes to CCIRs based on their assessments of the operation.

2-78. Commanders limit the number of CCIRs to focus the efforts of limited collection assets. The fewer the CCIRs, the easier it is for their staff to remember, recognize, and act on each one. CCIRs constantly change.

Commanders add and delete them throughout an operation based on the information needed for specific decisions. They determine their own CCIRs and select some from staff nominations. Once approved, a CCIR falls into one of two categories: priority intelligence requirements and friendly force information requirements.

2-79. A *priority intelligence requirement* is the intelligence component of commander's critical information requirements used to focus the employment of limited intelligence assets and resources against competing demands for intelligence support (JP 2-0). Priority intelligence requirements identify the information about the enemy and the operational environment that the commander considers most important. Intelligence about civil considerations may be as critical as intelligence about the enemy.

2-80. A *friendly force information requirement* is information the commander and staff need to understand the status of friendly force and supporting capabilities (JP 3-0). Friendly force information requirements identify the information about the mission, troops and support available, and time available for friendly forces that the commander considers most important to mission accomplishment.

Essential Elements of Friendly Information

2-81. Commanders describe information they want protected as essential elements of friendly information. An ***essential element of friendly information*** is a critical aspect of a friendly operation that, if known by a threat, would subsequently compromise, lead to failure, or limit success of the operation and therefore should be protected from enemy detection. Although essential elements of friendly information are not CCIRs, they have the same priority. Essential elements of friendly information establish elements of information to protect rather than ones to collect. Their identification is the first step in the operations security process and is central to the protection of information. (Refer to ADP 3-13 for details on protecting information.)

DIRECT

2-82. Commanders direct action to achieve results and lead forces to mission accomplishment. Commanders direct action based on their situational understanding maintained by continuous assessment. Throughout the operations process, commanders direct forces by—

- Preparing and approving plans and orders.
- Establishing command and support relationships.
- Assigning and adjusting tasks, control measures, and task organization.
- Positioning units to maximize combat power.
- Positioning key leaders at critical places and times to ensure supervision.
- Allocating resources to exploit opportunities and counter threats.
- Committing the reserve as required.

LEAD

2-83. Commanders lead by example and personal presence. Leadership inspires subordinates to accomplish things that they otherwise might not. Where a commander is located within an assigned area is an important consideration for effective mission command. There is no standard pattern or simple prescription to leadership; each commander leads differently. Commanders balance their time among the staff, subordinate commanders, forces, and other organizations to make the greatest contribution to success.

Through leadership, commanders provide purpose, direction, and motivation to subordinate commanders, staff, and Soldiers.

ASSESS

2-84. Commanders continuously assess current conditions to improve their situational understanding and determine how an operation is progressing. Continuous assessment helps commanders anticipate and adapt the force to changing circumstances. Commanders incorporate the assessments of their staff, subordinate commanders, and unified action partners into their personal assessment of the situation. Based on their assessment, commanders adjust their visualization and modify plans to adapt the force to changing circumstances.

GUIDES TO EFFECTIVE COMMAND

2-85. Guides to effective command help commanders fulfill the fundamental responsibilities of command. A commander's use of these guides fits the situation, the commander's personality, and the capability and understanding of subordinates. Command cannot be scripted. These guides apply at all levels of command. Mission command provides a common baseline for command during operations and garrison activities. These guides aid commanders in effectively exercising command and promoting mission command:

- Create a positive command climate.
- Ensure unity of effort.
- Train subordinates on C2 and mission command.
- Make timely and effective decisions and act.

CREATE A POSITIVE COMMAND CLIMATE

2-86. Commanders create their organization's tone—the atmosphere in which people work. This is known as the command climate. It is directly attributable to the leader's values, skills, and actions. A positive climate facilitates team building; encourages initiative; and fosters collaboration, mutual trust, and shared understanding. Commanders shape the climate of their organization, no matter what the size.

2-87. Successful commanders recognize that all subordinates contribute to mission accomplishment. They establish clear and realistic goals and communicate those goals openly. Commanders establish and maintain open, candid communication between subordinate leaders. They encourage subordinates to bring creative and innovative ideas to the forefront. They also seek feedback from subordinates. The result is a command climate that encourages initiative.

2-88. In a positive command climate, the expectation is that everyone lives by and upholds the moral principles of the Army ethic. The Army ethic must be embraced, supported, practiced, and respected. Mission command depends on a command climate that encourages subordinate commanders at all levels to take the initiative. Commanders create a positive command climate by—

- Accepting subordinates' risk taking and errors.
- Building mutual trust and shared understanding.
- Communicating with subordinates.
- Building teams.

A positive command climate instills a sense of trust within units. It facilitates a strong sense of discipline, comradeship, self-respect, and morale.

(Refer to AR 600-20, ADP 6-22, and FM 6-22 for more information on creating a positive command climate.)

Accept Subordinates' Risk Taking and Errors

2-89. Exercising initiative requires a command climate that promotes risk taking. Commanders impress the willingness to accept risk into their commands through leading by example and accepting subordinates' risk taking. In training, commanders may allow subordinates to execute an excessively risky decision, as long as it does not endanger lives, as a teaching point. This training helps commanders gain trust in their subordinates' judgment and initiative and builds subordinates' trust in their commander.

2-90. Instilling risk acceptance among subordinates requires that commanders accept risk themselves. Subordinates will not always succeed, particularly when inexperienced. However, with risk acceptance in the command climate, subordinates learn and gain the experience required to operate on their own. In addition, subordinates learn to trust their commander to give them authority to act, knowing their commander will back their decisions.

2-91. Commanders do not underwrite subordinate mistakes when a subordinate operates outside of the commander's intent or displays poor judgment that endangers life or mission accomplishment. Commanders do not tolerate a subordinate who repeatedly makes the same mistakes, does not learn, or violates the Army ethic. Discriminating between which mistakes to underwrite as teaching points and which mistakes are unacceptable in a military leader is part of the art of command.

Build Mutual Trust and Shared Understanding

2-92. Mutual trust and shared understanding are critical to subordinates' exercise of initiative. Mutual trust and shared understanding of the commander's intent free commanders to move about the battlefield. Commanders know their subordinates understand the desired end state, and subordinates know their commander will support their decisions. Additionally, this command climate allows commanders to operate, knowing subordinates will accurately and promptly report both positive and negative information.

Communicate with Subordinates

2-93. Communicating with subordinates contributes to the shared understanding fundamental to mission command. Effective commanders take steps to encourage communication among and with their subordinates and staff. Candor and the free exchange of ideas contribute to trust. Commanders make themselves available for communications and open to new information. They create a climate where collaboration routinely occurs through personal example, coaching, and mentorship. Successful commanders invest the time and effort to visit and engage with Soldiers, subordinate leaders, and unified action partners to understand their issues and concerns. Through these interactions, subordinates and partners gain insight into the commander's leadership style and concerns.

Build Teams

2-94. Army organizations rely on effective teams to complete tasks, achieve objectives, and accomplish missions. The ability to build and maintain effective teams throughout military operations is an essential skill for all Army commanders, staffs, and leaders.

2-95. *Army team building* is a continuous process of enabling a group of people to reach their goals and improve their effectiveness through leadership and various exercises, activities and techniques (FM 6-22). The goal of Army team building is to improve the quality of the team and how it works together to accomplish the mission. Using doctrinal terms and symbols is one method of fostering teamwork. Often, the only basis for trust and teamwork in situations that require rapid task organization is a common language and approach to operations. Training and rehearsals also provide opportunities to foster teamwork. Teambuilding is essential to achieving the effective teams required of mission command.

2-96. Building an effective team is challenging, but the positive benefits of teamwork in an effective team are well worth the effort and time it takes. These benefits enhance the performance of the team, improve the skills of the individual team members, and build important relationships with unified action partners.

2-97. Commanders foster teamwork among task-organized units. Commanders initiate team building as early as possible, and they maintain it throughout operations. Commanders trust and earn the trust of their unified action partners and key leaders within the assigned area. Overcoming differences in cultures, mandates, and organizational capabilities is key to building mutual trust with unified action partners and key leaders.

2-98. Commanders use interpersonal relationships to build teams within their own organizations and with unified action partners. Uniting all the diverse capabilities necessary to achieve success in operations requires collaborative and cooperative efforts that focus those capabilities toward a common goal. Where military forces typically demand unity of command, a challenge for building teams with unified action partners is to forge unity of effort—coordination and cooperation toward common objectives. (Refer to JP 3-08 for more information on teambuilding with unified action partners.)

ENSURE UNITY OF EFFORT

2-99. Unity of command is one of the principles of war and the preferred method for achieving unity of effort. Under unity of command, every mission falls within the authority and responsibility of a single, responsible commander. Two commanders may not exercise the same command relationship over the same force at any one time. (Refer to FM 3-0 for more information on Army command relationships.) Unity of command may not be possible in some operations that include unified action partners, but the requirement for unity of effort remains paramount. When unity of command is not possible, commanders achieve unity of effort through cooperation and coordination to build trust among all elements of the force—even if they are not part of the same command structure.

2-100. *Unity of effort* is coordination and cooperation toward common objectives, even if the participants are not necessarily part of the same command or organization that is the product of successful unified action (JP 1, Volume 2). Establishing a culture of collaboration enhances unity of effort. The commander's intent provides the unifying idea that allows decentralized execution within an overarching framework. Understanding the commander's intent two echelons up further enhances unity of effort while providing the basis for decentralized decision making and execution. Subordinates who understand the commander's intent are more likely to exercise disciplined initiative in unexpected situations. Under mission command, subordinates have an absolute responsibility to fulfill the commander's intent.

TRAIN SUBORDINATES IN COMMAND AND CONTROL AND MISSION COMMAND

2-101. Commanders develop a basic level of control within their organizations when they create a culture that embraces mission command at every level. The time spent instilling mission command into training, education, and problem solving prior to operations saves time and simplifies C2 during operations. Commanders cannot expect subordinates to respond effectively to a mission command approach once operations commence if they have not helped subordinates be comfortable in its use beforehand.

2-102. Leaders have an obligation to ensure that their subordinates can perform their assigned tasks to Army standards under a variety of circumstances. Leaders generally provide more direction or guidance and control until they are satisfied that subordinates understand tasks, conditions, and standards and can operate within the commander's intent. Increased confidence in the ability of subordinates generally leads to more latitude given to subordinates to complete their assigned missions, since commanders can trust that the subordinates understand the purpose of what they are being told to do.

2-103. The ability to provide general guidance oriented to the purpose of a mission saves time during execution for both commanders and subordinates. It maximizes flexibility should conditions change or communication become intermittent. It also minimizes the chances that subordinates will waste resources on tasks no longer relevant to the purpose of a particular operation. The effort put into developing subordinate leaders and their teams saves critical time in combat and allows commanders to assume more risk when the situation is unclear and communication is intermittent.

2-104. Effective mission command requires well-developed subordinates capable of decentralized execution of missions and tasks. Training creates common, repetitive, and shared experiences that build trust and allow commands to acquire competence in shared understanding. Trained teams can communicate explicitly and implicitly, conduct decentralized operations, and achieve unity of effort in uncertain situations.

2-105. Noncommissioned officers are required to exercise disciplined initiative to make decisions and take actions to further their commander's intent. They actively work to understand the commander's intent two levels up and relay that intent to their Soldiers. They train to develop mutual trust and shared understanding with their commanders and their Soldiers. Noncommissioned officers enforce standards and discipline and develop their subordinates as they build teams. They are trained to operate under mission orders and decide for themselves how best to achieve their commander's intent.

Noncommissioned officers are key enablers of mission command and are trained on its principles.

2-106. As part of training subordinates in C2 and mission command, commanders prepare their subordinates for positions of increased responsibility. To this end, they promote leader qualities and assess subordinates' potential for future appointments to command and staff positions.

Promote Leader Qualities

2-107. Commanders promote leader requirements by developing them in themselves and in their subordinates at least two echelons down. These attributes and competencies are described in the Army leadership requirements model. This model describes the attributes and competencies required of Army leaders. But these attributes and competencies alone do not make successful commanders. Successful commanders develop a balance among those requirements. The fact that an officer has been appointed a commander does not automatically endow that commander with these attributes. Rather, all officers develop them to prepare for command. In general, the higher the echelon of command, the wider the scope of

attributes and competencies required. In addition, the emphasis on the qualities changes with the echelon of command. (Refer to ADP 6-22 for more information on the Army leadership requirements model.)

2-108. All commanders emphasize the Warrior Ethos. The Warrior Ethos is a set of principles by which every Soldier lives, and it states the following:

- I will always place the mission first.
- I will never accept defeat.
- I will never quit.
- I will never leave a fallen comrade behind.

2-109. Commanders continually affirm, develop, and sustain the Warrior Ethos to reinforce it. Developing it demands ingraining self-discipline in the commander, subordinates, and the command. It requires tough, realistic training that develops the resilience needed to endure extremes of weather, physical exertion, and lack of sleep and food. Commanders develop the will, determination, and confidence that they, their subordinates, and their formations will accomplish all missions regardless of conditions.

2-110. Training and education develop much of the knowledge and many of the skills commanders require. Training devices, simulations, and exercises enhance clarity of thought and judgment, including decision making. Developing leader qualities and practicing leadership skills is necessary for subordinates to decide and act effectively during operations.

Assess Subordinates

2-111. Once appointed, commanders assume the role of coach and mentor to their subordinates. They study the personalities and characteristics of their subordinates. Some need significant direction; others work best with little or no guidance. Some tire easily and require encouragement and moral support. Others, perhaps uninspired in peace, excel in conflict and war. Matching talent to tasks is an important function of command. Commanders judge Soldiers so they can appoint the right subordinates to the right positions at the right times. Commanders also assess subordinates by giving them experiences and opportunities to grow through assignments that challenge their abilities. Recognizing subordinates' strengths and limits is vital to effectively exercising command.

2-112. To assess the qualities of subordinates objectively, commanders place individuals in circumstances where they must make decisions and live with the consequences. In these situations, subordinates know their commander has enough confidence in them to permit honest mistakes. Training gives commanders opportunities to assess subordinates on the qualities leaders possess. Assessing subordinates should confirm whether they exhibit the necessary balance of intelligence, professionalism, and common sense required to succeed in positions of increased responsibility.

One of a commander's most important duties is evaluating subordinates to identify potential candidates for senior appointments to command and staff positions.

MAKE TIMELY DECISIONS AND ACT

2-113. Timely decisions and actions are essential for effective C2. Commanders who demonstrate the agility to consistently make appropriate decisions faster than their opponents have a significant advantage. By the time the slower commander decides and acts, the faster one has already changed the situation, rendering the slower commander's actions irrelevant. With such an advantage, the faster commander dictates the tempo and maintains the operational initiative.

2-114. A mission command approach makes it easier for commanders to make timely decisions that exploit opportunities because they spend less time focused on subordinates' tasks. Effective commanders—

- Take the enemy situation, capabilities, and reaction times into account when making decisions.
- Consider the impact of their decisions.
- Make decisions quickly, even with incomplete information.
- Adopt a satisfactory course of action with acceptable risk as quickly as possible.
- Delegate decision making authority to the lowest echelon possible to obtain faster decisions during operations.
- Support decentralized execution by maintaining shared understanding with subordinates and adjacent commanders.

2-115. Commanders can abbreviate planning to fit time-constrained circumstances. In time-constrained conditions, commanders assess the situation, update their visualization, and direct their staff to perform those activities needed to support the required decisions. Streamlined processes permit commanders and staffs to shorten the time needed to issue orders when the situation changes. To an outsider, it may appear that experienced commanders and staffs omit key steps. In reality, they use existing products or perform steps mentally. Commanders ensure their staff are trained on all Army planning methodologies. (Refer to FM 5-0 for more information on the Army planning methodologies.)

2-116. Commanders and staffs constantly assess where an operation is in relation to the end state and make adjustments to accomplish the mission and posture the force for future operations. The commander's visualization and the staff's running estimates are the primary assessment tools. Keeping running estimates current is essential to ensuring commanders are aware of feasible options. Staffs continuously replace outdated facts and assumptions in their running estimate with new information. They perform analysis and form new or revise existing conclusions and recommendations. The commander's visualization identifies decisions commanders expect to make and focuses their staff's running estimates. Updated running estimates inform the recommendations commanders need to make timely decisions during execution. (Refer to FM 6-0 for more information on running estimates.)

Chapter 3

Control

This chapter begins with a discussion of the nature of control and its elements. A discussion of control measures follows. The chapter concludes with a discussion of guides for effective control.

NATURE OF CONTROL

3-1. Command alone is not sufficient to translate vision into action and assure mission accomplishment. Commanders also exercise control to direct and adjust operations as conditions dictate. Control is the regulation of forces and warfighting functions to accomplish the mission in accordance with the commander's intent. Determining the appropriate level of control, including delegating authorities and determining how much decentralized execution to employ, is an essential aspect of mission command. (See Chapter 1 for a discussion on levels of control.)

3-2. Control allows commanders to monitor and receive feedback regarding the situation during operations. Based on this information, commanders modify their visualization and direct changes to an operation as necessary. In the broadest terms, control helps commanders answer two questions:

- What is the actual situation compared with the desired end state?
- Are adjustments to the plan necessary to reconcile the situation with the desired end state?

3-3. Unlike aspects of command, which remain relatively similar among echelons, control functions increase in complexity at each higher echelon. Control extends over the entire force and may include control of the airspace over an assigned area below the coordinating altitude. (Refer to FM 3-52 for more discussion of airspace control.)

3-4. Control is more science than art. It relies on objectivity, facts, empirical methods, and analysis. The science of control supports the art of command. Commanders and staffs use the science of control to understand the physical and procedural constraints under which units operate. Units are bound by such factors as movement rates, fuel consumption, weapons effects, rules of engagement, and other legal considerations. Commanders and staffs strive to understand aspects of operations they can analyze and measure, such as the physical capabilities and limitations of friendly and enemy organizations.

3-5. Control requires a realistic appreciation of time and distance factors. This includes the time required to initiate, complete, and assess directed actions. There is art in anticipating likely points of friction and factors beyond subordinate control that invariably lead to delays during execution. The higher the echelon and the larger the formation, the longer it takes to complete assigned tasks. This in turn requires an earlier decision to achieve a desired effect or end state. The planning necessary to facilitate adequate control incorporates time tolerances that account for the friction inherent in operations.

3-6. One strength of mission command is that it provides a measure of self-regulation during the conduct of operations. Under mission command, control tends to be decentralized and flexible whenever possible in the context of operations. Orders and plans rely on subordinates' abilities to coordinate among themselves to create shared understanding and synchronize operations. By delegating decision-making authority to facilitate decentralized execution, mission command increases tempo by improving a subordinate's ability to act in rapidly changing situations. As a result, the mission command approach to C2 is inherently less vulnerable to disrupted communications.

ELEMENTS OF CONTROL

3-7. Commanders control operations by communicating information to direct the actions of subordinate forces. They receive information in the form of feedback from subordinates to achieve greater shared understanding and adjust operations as required. Commanders control by task-organizing forces and organizing their C2 system to meet the requirements of the situation. The elements of control are—

- Information.

- Communication.
- Organization.

INFORMATION

3-8. Information is central to everything Army forces do—it is the basis of intelligence and a fundamental element of control. Army forces collect, process, and analyze data and relevant information to develop situational understanding. Commanders and staffs leverage data analytics, data orchestration, and knowledge management techniques to analyze data and information to enhance situational understanding and decision making. Additionally, operational and mission variables help commanders understand the environment and factors that affect a mission. These enable commanders to respond more quickly to changing situations and adapt their plans and operations accordingly. Commanders then communicate their decisions to subordinates and direct actions. Based on feedback and assessment of the situation, commanders adjust operations as required.

Relevant Information

3-9. Operations produce large amounts of data and information. While much of this may be important to the staff or the conduct of operations, it may not be relevant information for the commander. **Relevant information is all information of importance to the commander and staff in the exercise of command and control.** Commanders, supported by their staff, use relevant information to maintain their running estimates; to build shared understanding across the force; and to direct, coordinate, and synchronize the action of subordinate units.

3-10. Commanders determine information requirements and set information priorities. They avoid requesting excessive amounts of information, which may reduce the staff's chances of finding what is important in a particular situation. The quest for information is time consuming; commanders who demand complete information place unreasonable burdens upon subordinates. Subordinates pressured to worry over every detail rarely have the desire to exercise initiative. At worst, excessive information demands corrupt the trust required for a mission command approach. Commanders describe the relevant information they need to inform decision making by establishing CCIRs. (See Chapter 2 for a detailed discussion of CCIRs.)

Commanders limit information requests to that which is critical to decision making.

3-11. Relevant information provides the basis for running estimates and for creating and maintaining the COP. This information facilitates situational understanding, decision making, and the ability to provide timely orders and guidance. Relevant information generally has the following characteristics:

- Accurate: it conveys the true situation.
- Timely: it is available in time to make decisions.
- Usable: it is portrayed in common, easily understood formats and displays.
- Complete: it provides all information necessary.
- Precise: it contains the necessary detail.
- Reliable: it is trustworthy and dependable.

Note. The intelligence warfighting function requires relevant information to be predictive and tailored.

3-12. Commanders and staffs assess information in the context of a particular situation. In some situations, information that is somewhat incomplete or imprecise may be better than no information at all, especially when time for execution is limited. However, effective commanders act with their staff and subordinates to reduce the likelihood of receiving inaccurate, late, or unreliable information. They do this by setting expectations, conducting training, and providing education.

3-13. Commanders and staffs assess the value and reliability of data and information in relation to the mission and operational context. Doing so requires leaders to be data literate. **Data literacy is the ability to read, understand, and evaluate data.** With strong data

Leaders are data literate to critically evaluate and use the results of data analysis to inform their decision-making.

literacy, commanders and staffs maximize decision optimization practices. These practices determine which data is most relevant to the mission, ensuring decisions are based on timely, accurate, and relevant information.

Data Analytics

3-14. **Data analytics is the process of transforming sets of data to identify patterns, trends, and insights.** It is a multidisciplinary field of study that encompasses data analysis, data science, and data engineering. Data analytics employs a wide range of analysis techniques (such as math and statistics) and technologies (such as artificial intelligence and machine learning).

3-15. Data analytics enhances the identification of relevant information by processing large volumes of data to identify patterns, trends, and relationships aligned to CCIRs. It helps commanders and staffs focus on data that directly supports decision points, mission objectives, and critical information requirements. Data analytics can transform unprocessed data into clear, actionable information.

3-16. For Army leaders, data literacy begins by understanding the four levels of data analysis and how each contributes to situational understanding through the cognitive hierarchy. Each of the four data analytics levels (descriptive, diagnostic, predictive, and prescriptive) involves a deeper and more complex analysis with data. As an organization moves from descriptive to prescriptive analysis, the analytical techniques become more technically sophisticated. At the same time, potential insights become increasingly useful to decision makers.

Note. The Army recruits, trains, and educates Soldiers and Army civilian professionals to serve as data analysts, data engineers, software developers, and data scientists in the operational and institutional force. These high-demand and low-density specialists are normally assigned at echelons above brigade in the operational force. Lower echelons benefit from the analysis and products developed at higher echelons.

Descriptive Analytics

3-17. Descriptive analytics is the foundational level of data analytics, focusing on summarizing historical data to understand what has happened and when it happened. The goal is to provide a clear picture of historical data and trends. This level of analytics involves data aggregation and mining techniques to provide insight into past events and performance. It includes statistical measures like mean, median, and mode and data visualization tools like charts and graphs. Descriptive analytics answers questions such as “What happened?” and “How many?” Descriptive analytics in a military context can be compared with the first three steps of intelligence preparation of the operational environment (define the operational environment, describe the environmental effects on operations, evaluate the threat).

Diagnostic Analytics

3-18. Diagnostic analytics explains why something happened by identifying patterns and correlations within the data. It uses techniques like correlation analysis to find relationships between variables and data mining to uncover hidden patterns within large datasets. By identifying these connections and root causes, diagnostic analytics seeks to answer questions such as, “Why did this happen?” and “What are the underlying reasons?” This process helps to understand the underlying reasons for past outcomes.

Predictive Analytics

3-19. Predictive analytics uses historical data and statistical algorithms to forecast future events. The goal is to predict what is likely to happen based on patterns observed in the past. It provides insights into future events by analyzing historical data and identifying trends. Techniques include regression analysis, statistical modeling, time series analysis, and machine learning algorithms. Predictive analytics answers questions such as “What is likely to happen in the future?” and “What trends can we expect?” Predictive analytics in a military context can be compared to step four of intelligence preparation of the operational environment (determine threat courses of action).

Prescriptive Analytics

3-20. Prescriptive analytics suggests actions that can affect desired outcomes. It predicts what will happen and provides recommendations for facing future scenarios. Prescriptive analysis suggests actionable recommendations and strategies based on predictive insights. It answers questions like “What should we do?” and “How can we make it happen?” The purpose of prescriptive analytics is to determine the best course of action. This last level involves complex algorithms and advanced tools, such as simulation, to advise on possible outcomes and their impacts.

Note. Data analytics can produce powerful insights. However, they are no substitute for the leader's judgment. Data analytics can provide evidence for a decision, but it is up to leaders to judge the strength of that evidence. Although commanders and other decision makers do not need to know how to perform sophisticated data analyses, they do need to be data literate enough to understand their capabilities, limitations, and implications.

Data Orchestration

3-21. *Data orchestration* is the process of synchronizing, integrating, and prioritizing data to enhance shared understanding and decision making (ATP 6-0.7). Data orchestration supports the timely delivery of relevant information by synchronizing data flows to prioritize information aligned to CCIRs. It ensures relevant information is prioritized, accurate, and accessible by eliminating redundancies, addressing gaps, and integrating data from multiple sources. This enables commanders and staffs to focus on the information that is most important, supporting clear understanding and timely, informed decisions.

Knowledge Management

3-22. **Knowledge management is an integrating process that enhances knowledge flow to improve shared understanding, decision making, organizational performance, and learning.** The purpose of knowledge management is to align people, processes, and tools within the organizational structure to achieve shared understanding and drive action. This alignment improves collaboration and interaction between leaders and subordinates. Knowledge management leads to better decisions and increases flexibility, integration, and synchronization. Sound knowledge management practices include—

Knowledge flow refers to the ease of movement of knowledge within and among organizations.

- Collaboration among personnel at different locations.
- Rapid knowledge transfer between units and individuals.

3-23. Knowledge management provides the methods and means to efficiently share knowledge and distribute relevant information where and when it is needed. Knowledge management organizes, applies, collects, codifies, and exchanges information between people. It seeks to align people and processes with appropriate tools to help units learn, adapt, and improve mission performance. Knowledge management is supported by four tasks that bring an organization closer to situational and shared understanding. The four knowledge management tasks are creating knowledge, organizing knowledge, applying knowledge, and transferring knowledge. (Refer to ATP 6-01.1 for more information on knowledge management.)

3-24. Two important aspects of knowledge management are information management and foreign disclosure. **Information management is the science of using procedures and information systems to collect, process, store, display, disseminate, and protect data, information, and knowledge products.** Information management supports, underpins, and enables knowledge management. The two are linked to facilitate understanding and decision making. Information management is a technical discipline that involves planning, storing, manipulating, and controlling data and information throughout its life cycle in support of the commander and staff. Information management employs staff management and processes to make information available to the right person at the right time. Information management provides a structure so commanders and staffs can process and communicate relevant information and make decisions. Effective information management contributes to the knowledge management tasks of knowledge creation and supports shared understanding for all unit members. (Refer to FM 6-02 for further discussion on information management.)

3-25. Foreign disclosure is a critical part of interoperability with multinational partners. Conducting operations with unified action partners affects the way the force collects and disseminates information. The disclosure of classified and controlled unclassified information to foreign representatives is governed by policy and regulations. Keeping as much information unclassified as possible improves interoperability, operational effectiveness, and trust. While conducting operations, commanders and staffs ensure they know other nations' positions on intelligence sharing. They ensure that intelligence is shared to the degree possible, especially if required for mission accomplishment and force protection. Early information sharing during planning ensures that unified action partner requirements are clearly stated, guidance supports the commander's intent, and the force uses procedures supportable by other nations. (Refer to AR 380-10 and ATP 3-16.02 for more discussions on foreign disclosure.)

Operational and Mission Variables

3-26. Operational and mission variables are crucial for commanders and their staff as they provide the necessary information to understand the operational environment and monitor the progress of operations. Utilizing the operational variables—political, military, economic, social, information, infrastructure, physical environment, and time—in conjunction with mission variables—mission, enemy, terrain and weather, troops and support available, time available, civil considerations, and informational considerations—enables a comprehensive analysis of relevant factors affecting the mission. By analyzing these interrelated operational variables, leaders develop a deeper understanding of the operational environment and its impact on mission success. This integrated approach ensures that Army leaders utilize the best available information to refine their situational awareness and effectively visualize, describe, direct, lead, and assess operations. (Refer to FM 5-0 for detailed discussion of the operational and mission variables.)

COMMUNICATION

3-27. Commanders and staffs communicate information among people and places. Communication is more than the simple transmission of information. It is a means to exercise control over forces. Communication links information to decisions and decisions to action. Communication among the parts of a command supports coordinated action. Effective commanders do not take communication for granted. They use multidirectional communication and suitable communication media to achieve objectives. Commanders choose appropriate times, places, and means to communicate. They use written and verbal orders, estimates and plans, published memos, electronic mail, and other methods of communication appropriate for a particular situation.

3-28. Commanders and staffs continuously communicate to learn, exchange ideas, and create sustained shared understanding. Information needs to flow up and down the chain of command, as well as laterally to adjacent units and organizations. Separate from the quality or meaning of information exchanged, communication strengthens bonds within a command. It is an important factor in building trust, cooperation, cohesion, and mutual understanding.

3-29. Humans communicate verbally by what they say and in their manner of speaking. They also communicate nonverbally with gestures and body language. Commanders pay attention to verbal and nonverbal feedback to ascertain the effectiveness of their communication and the way it is received. Commanders conduct face-to-face talks with their subordinates to ensure subordinates fully understand them. This does not mean they do not keep records of information communicated or follow-up with written documentation. Records are important as a means of affirming understanding and for later study and critique. Records support understanding over time, whereas memory may distort or even omit elements of the information required or passed.

3-30. In many cases, commanders rely too much on written communications, especially digital. Written products, briefs, and directives do not have the same impact as oral orders, consultations, and briefings. Staffs possess the ability to produce vast amounts of documents; however, just because the capability exists does not mean it should be used. Quality communications are superior to an excessive quantity of communications for enabling a mission command approach to C2.

3-31. Enemy action and environmental conditions degrade communications. Commanders' intent and orders are written in a way that enables subordinates to achieve objectives when communication is intermittent and situational awareness is problematic. Mission orders and application of the mission command approach to C2 mitigate the need for continuous communication.

Commanders assume that communications will be disrupted during operations.

Direction and Feedback

3-32. Commanders, through their C2 system, direct subordinates by establishing objectives, assigning tasks, and providing instruction on how forces will cooperate to accomplish the mission. (See Chapter 4 for more information on the C2 system). The primary means for communicating directions include plans and orders. Mission orders focus subordinates on what to do and why to do it without prescribing exactly how to do it. (See Chapter 1 for more information on mission orders). Other tools for providing direction include execution matrices, the decision support template, and control measures.

3-33. Commanders use feedback to compare the actual situation with the plan and then decide if the plan requires any changes or adjustments. Feedback comes from many sources: subordinates; higher headquarters; or adjacent, supporting, and supported forces. It arrives continuously: before, during, and after operations. Feedback helps commanders and subordinates gain shared understanding. For feedback to be effective, it identifies any differences between the desired end state and the current situation. New information that conflicts with the expectations established during planning requires commanders and staffs to validate those expectations or revise them to reflect reality. This contributes to an accurate situational understanding that allows commanders to exploit fleeting opportunities, respond to developing situations, modify plans, or reallocate resources.

3-34. Feedback does not flow only from lower to higher headquarters; it also flows from higher to lower headquarters. Normally, information from higher echelons to lower echelon headquarters consists of information to adjust the subordinates' resources, plans, or missions. Multidirectional communication produces shared understanding between higher commanders and subordinate forces that supports exercise of mission command.

3-35. Effective commanders seek feedback from subordinates who are comfortable providing both positive and negative reports. Commanders whose command climates make subordinates reluctant to share bad news are likely to be poorly informed and operate from faulty assumptions that put operations at risk.

Channels

3-36. Information moves throughout a force along various transmission paths or channels. Commanders and staffs transfer information horizontally and vertically. Structure, in the form of command and support relationships, establishes channels that streamline information dissemination by ensuring the right information passes promptly to the right people. Commanders and staffs communicate through three channels—command, staff, and technical.

Command Channels

3-37. Command channels facilitate direct interaction both vertically and laterally within the chain of command. These channels enable commanders to share command assessments and intuition, resulting in faster decisions when necessary. By maintaining open lines of communication, commanders ensure that relevant information flows smoothly throughout all echelons, enhancing situational awareness and operational effectiveness.

Staff Channels

3-38. Staff channels are staff-to-staff transmission paths between headquarters. Staff channels transmit planning information, status reports, controlling instructions, and other information to support C2. The intelligence and sustainment networks are examples of staff channels.

Technical Channels

3-39. Technical channels are the transmission paths between two technically similar units, offices, or staff sections that perform a technical function requiring special expertise or control the performance of technical functions. Technical channels are typically used to control performance of technical functions. They are not used for conducting operations or supporting another unit's mission. An example is network operations. The activities for the operation, management, and control of communications transport are routinely performed by network operations control centers.

ORGANIZATION

3-40. Organizational structure helps commanders communicate information and exercise control. Organizational structure refers to a defined organization that establishes relationships and information flow and guides interactions among elements. It also includes procedures for coordinating among an organization's groups and activities. Commanders establish control with a defined organization. To facilitate effective control, commanders—

- Organize forces.
- Organize the C2 system.

Organize Forces

3-41. *Task-organizing* is the act of designing a force, support staff, or sustainment package of specific size and composition to meet a unique task or mission (ADP 3-0). It includes providing assets to subordinate commanders and establishing their command and support relationships. Task-organizing results in a *task organization*—a temporary grouping of forces designed to accomplish a particular mission (ADP 5-0). The unit's task organization is stipulated in the base plan or order or addressed in Annex A (Task Organization) to the base plan or order.

3-42. Command and support relationships provide the basis for unity of command and are essential to the exercise of control. Army command relationships define command responsibility and authority. Army support relationships define the purpose, scope, and effect desired when one capability supports another. Command and support relationships are doctrinally defined and establish clear responsibilities and authorities between subordinate and supporting units. Knowing the inherent responsibilities of each command and support relationship allows commanders to effectively organize their forces and helps supporting commanders understand their unit's role in the organizational structure. (Refer to FM 3-0 for a detailed discussion of Army command and support relationships.)

Establishing clear command and support relationships is fundamental to organizing for any operation.

Organize the Command and Control System

3-43. The C2 system is the arrangement of people, processes, data and networks, and C2 nodes that enable commanders to conduct operations. Commanders organize a C2 system to—

- Support the commander's decision making.
- Collect, create, and maintain relevant information.
- Prepare products to support the commander's and leaders' understanding and visualization.
- Prepare and communicate directives.

3-44. Commanders also organize numerous activities, meetings, and reports within their headquarters, and with higher, subordinate, supporting, and adjacent units as part of the operations process. They do this by establishing the unit's battle rhythm. *Battle rhythm* is a deliberate, daily schedule of command, staff, and unit activities intended to maximize use of time and synchronize staff actions (JP 3-33). The battle rhythm provides structure for managing the most important internal resource of a headquarters—the time of the commander and staff—through a series of synchronized meetings, report requirements, and activities tailored to the needs of the operation.

3-45. To effectively integrate a unit's battle rhythm, it is essential to recognize that the C2 nodes serve as the focal points of C2. **A command and control node is a scalable and survivable configuration of the command and control system designed to enable commanders to effectively command and control**

operations. These nodes, which can be physical or virtual locations, are established to effectively integrate people, processes, data and networks to perform their assigned functions.

3-46. C2 nodes facilitate coordination and communication across all elements of the unit. C2 nodes embody the functions and capabilities necessary for effective operations. These C2 nodes are designed to be mobile, scalable, and survivable, allowing commanders to maintain flexibility and responsiveness in the field. Each node has specific roles and responsibilities, highlighting that no single node can fulfill all required functions independently.

3-47. The effectiveness of the C2 system hinges on the integration and coordination of tasks across all C2 nodes. This networked approach ensures that commanders have the situational awareness and decision-making capabilities essential for leading operations successfully on the modern battlefield. By organizing the C2 system effectively, commanders enhance their operational effectiveness and maintain the agility required to adapt to dynamic conditions.

CONTROL MEASURES

3-48. Commanders use control measures to assign responsibilities, coordinate fire and maneuver, and control operations. **A control measure is a means of regulating forces or warfighting functions.** Control measures provide control without requiring detailed explanations. Control measures help commanders establish responsibilities and limits that prevent subordinate unit actions from impeding one another. They foster coordination and cooperation between forces without unnecessarily restricting freedom of action. Control measures may be detailed (such as an operation order) or simple (such as a checkpoint). Control measures include plans and orders, laws and regulations, and unit standard operating procedures.

3-49. Some control measures are graphic. **A graphic control measure is a symbol used on maps and displays to regulate forces and warfighting functions.** Graphic control measures are always prescriptive. They include symbols for maneuver control measures, fire support coordination measures, airspace coordinating measures, and air defense measures. Commanders establish them to regulate maneuver, movement, airspace use, fires, and other aspects of operations. In general, all graphic control measures relate to easily identifiable natural or man-made terrain features. (Refer to FM 1-02.2 and JP 3-52 for illustrations of graphic control measures and rules for their use.)

3-50. Control measures are established under a commander's authority. However, commanders may authorize staff officers and subordinate leaders to establish them. Commanders use control measures for several purposes: to assign responsibilities, require synchronization between forces, impose restrictions, or establish guidelines to regulate freedom of action. Certain control measures belong to the commander alone, and they may not be delegated. These include the commanders' intent, unit mission statement, planning guidance, CCIRs, and essential elements of friendly information.

3-51. Commanders tailor their use of control measures to conform to the higher echelon commander's intent. They also consider the mission, terrain, and amount of authority delegated to subordinates. Effectively employing control measures requires commanders and staffs to understand their purposes and ramifications, including the permissions or limitations imposed on subordinates' freedom of action and initiative. Each measure has a specific purpose: mass the effects of combat power, synchronize subordinate forces' operations, minimize the possibility of fratricide or civilian harm, or comply with the law of armed conflict.

Good control measures foster freedom of action, decision making, initiative, and reporting during operations.

3-52. The most important control measure is the boundary. Boundaries define the area of operations assigned to a commander. Commanders have full freedom of action to conduct operations within the boundaries of their assigned area, unless the order establishing the area of operations includes constraints.

GUIDES TO EFFECTIVE CONTROL

3-53. The guides to effective control govern how commanders use the elements of control to accomplish missions. Effective control enables a command to adapt to change. Through feedback, control is cyclic and continuous, not a series of discrete actions. It is a process of dynamic, interactive cooperation. Control begins during planning and continues throughout the operations process. The guides to effective control are—

- Allow subordinates maximum freedom of decision and action.
- Create, maintain, and disseminate the COP.
- Use common doctrinal procedures, graphics, and terms.
- Encourage flexibility and adaptability.

ALLOW SUBORDINATES MAXIMUM FREEDOM OF DECISION AND ACTION

3-54. Effective commanders impose minimum constraints on subordinates to enable freedom of action while meeting the overall intent. They exercise the control necessary to effect coordination and synchronization among subordinate and supporting forces. Commanders monitor this coordination and allocate available resources or shift priorities to support the actions of subordinate commanders. Allowing subordinates maximum freedom of action requires a mission command approach.

3-55. In most instances, lower echelon commanders have the clearest understanding of their own situations. They are generally better suited than higher echelon commanders to develop those situations. Even two or more subordinate commanders working together may solve a problem better and faster than the higher echelon commander. This type of coordination, involving direct communication among subordinate commanders, is critical for effective decentralized execution. Commanders emphasize lateral coordination at every opportunity.

3-56. Commanders avoid establishing excessive limits on their subordinates' freedom of action. These limits may come in the form of overly detailed orders that inhibit initiative and force subordinates to refer large numbers of decisions to their higher headquarters. Excessive detail may be a result of emphasizing process or procedure rather than an outcome—directing things already addressed in doctrine or standard operating procedures. Commanders consider these items when deciding how to exercise control:

- Limit control measures to those necessary to effect essential coordination.
- Limit information requirements to the minimum needed to facilitate decision making.
- Give subordinates as much leeway for initiative as possible.

CREATE, MAINTAIN, AND DISSEMINATE THE COMMON OPERATIONAL PICTURE

3-57. **The common operational picture is a display of relevant information within a commander's area of interest tailored to the user's requirements and based on common data and information shared by more than one command.** The COP is key to achieving and maintaining situational understanding. Although the COP is ideally a single display, it may include more than one display and information in other forms, such as graphic representations or written reports.

3-58. The COP facilitates collaborative planning and helps commanders at all echelons achieve shared situational understanding. Shared situational understanding allows commanders to visualize the effects of their decisions on other elements of the force and the overall operation. Mission command allows subordinates to use the COP in conjunction with the commander's intent to guide their exercise of disciplined initiative.

3-59. Commanders achieve situational understanding by applying judgment to the COP. Relevant information provides the basis for constructing the COP. It primarily consists of information which the staff provides through analysis and evaluation. Some sources of this information include reports, running estimates, and information provided by liaison officers.

3-60. Maintaining an accurate COP is difficult for many reasons: enemy interference, delayed or inaccurate friendly and intelligence reporting, terrain data availability, and a constantly changing operational environment. Fog and friction often degrade the accuracy of the COP or render part of it incorrect due to latency, enemy deception plans, or incorrect reporting. Staffs, based on guidance from their commanders, work to rapidly and accurately portray the meaning and the necessary level of information which help commanders maintain situational understanding and update their visualizations. Staffs only display information that is relevant to the commander's decision making and avoid overloading their commander with unnecessary details.

3-61. Units continually refine the COP during operations based on information they receive. By collaborating and sharing relevant information and tailoring it to their needs, separate echelons create their own COPs that show what their commanders need to know, as the situation requires.

3-62. Units draw on a common set of relevant information within a shared database to create a digital COP. When a digital COP is not possible due to the situation, including network interruptions, C2 nodes employ an analog COP. In this case, creation of a COP is done manually with physical maps and overlays that require training to employ effectively. The use of overlays or gathering subordinates around a common map or graphic are examples of applying the COP concept in an analog C2 node.

3-63. Maintaining a COP between units within any organization is a challenge. Maintaining a COP between different countries in a multinational environment is more of a challenge. The difficulty level varies based on language differences and technical compatibility of systems. Often unified action partners will not have the technical capability or compatible systems to create and share a digital COP. Commanders recognize and plan for this possibility.

USE DOCTRINALLY CORRECT TERMS AND GRAPHICS

3-64. Language used when communicating is simple, clear, and easily understood. An understanding of common doctrinal procedures, graphics, and terms contributes to the simplicity and clarity essential to mutual understanding. It also shortens the amount of explicit communication needed to convey or explain an order or plan. Doctrinal terms and graphics enable shared understanding by communicating in a commonly understood way. However, there are situations where staffs need to create nonstandard graphics or modify existing graphics to portray the environment, an adaptive opponent, or other elements. They do this only when standard graphics are unsuitable, and they ensure that subordinates and adjacent units understand nonstandard terms and graphics.

3-65. Doctrine clearly distinguishes between descriptive and prescriptive information. Most doctrine is descriptive; it is applied with judgment in the context of a particular situation. However, there are some reasons that Army forces apply some aspects of doctrine prescriptively, meaning done without deviation. Prescriptive doctrine derives from the need to—

- Adhere to the Army ethic, laws of war, national law, the Uniform Code of Military Justice, and Army regulations.
- Use terms, symbols, and the language of the profession precisely to ensure a common understanding.
- Adhere to control measures to ensure coordination, ensure synchronization, and prevent fratricide.
- Use report, message, and order formats to ensure information is reported rapidly, accurately, and in a commonly understood manner.

ENCOURAGE FLEXIBILITY AND ADAPTABILITY

3-66. Control allows organizations to respond to change, whether due to threat or friendly actions or environmental conditions. The mission command approach provides flexibility and adaptability, allowing subordinates to recognize and respond effectively to emerging conditions and to correct for the effects of fog and friction.

3-67. Control supports flexibility and adaptability in two ways. First, it identifies the need to change the plan. It does this through anticipating or forecasting possible adversary actions and by identifying unexpected variances (opportunities, threats, or risks) from the plan. This occurs throughout the operations process. Second, control helps commanders develop and implement options to respond to these changes in a timely manner. Flexibility and adaptability provided by the appropriate level of control reduce an adversary's available options while maintaining or expanding friendly options. Effective control provides for timely action before adversaries can accomplish their objectives, allowing for the modification of plans as the situation changes.

3-68. Instead of rigidly adhering to the plan, control focuses on information about emerging conditions. The mission command approach to control provides flexibility by—

- Allowing friendly forces to rapidly change their tasks, their task organization, or their plan in response to changing circumstances.
- Producing information about options to respond to changing conditions.
- Communicating the commander's decisions quickly and accurately.
- Providing rapid reframing when the plan changes during execution.
- Allowing collaborative planning and execution to respond to the progress of operations.

Chapter 4

The Command and Control Warfighting Function

This chapter defines and describes the C2 warfighting function. It next describes the C2 tasks, followed by a discussion of the C2 system. The chapter concludes with guides for organizing the C2 system.

INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMAND AND CONTROL WARFIGHTING FUNCTION

4-1. The C2 warfighting function includes the C2 system and the related tasks that enable commanders to exercise authority and direction to accomplish missions. The primary purpose of the C2 warfighting function is to assist commanders in integrating forces and synchronizing the other warfighting functions at each echelon to achieve objectives and accomplish missions. The C2 warfighting function consists of tasks and the C2 system as shown in Figure 4-1.

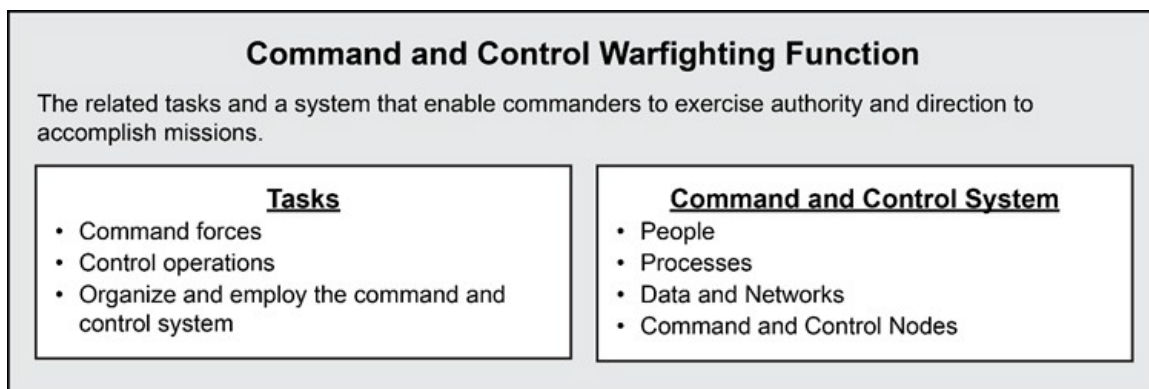


Figure 4-1. Components of the Command and Control Warfighting Function

4-2. The C2 warfighting function enables commanders to exercise authority and direction to achieve mission success. The entire C2 system is designed to support commanders in their abilities to understand, visualize, describe, direct, lead, and assess faster and more effectively than their opponents. Commanders, supported by their staff, conduct the operations process and integrating processes to exercise C2 throughout the conduct of operations.

COMMAND AND CONTROL TASKS

4-3. C2 tasks focus on integrating forces and synchronizing the warfighting functions to achieve objectives and accomplish missions. While there are numerous sub-tasks associated with C2, the primary C2 warfighting tasks are—

- Command forces.
- Control operations.
- Organize and employ the C2 system.

COMMAND FORCES

4-4. Inherent in command is the authority that a military commander lawfully exercises over subordinates, including authority to assign missions and accountability for their successful completion. Although commanders may delegate authority to accomplish missions, they do not absolve themselves of the responsibility for the attainment of these missions. Authority is never absolute; the extent of authority is specified by the establishing authority, directives, and law. (See Chapter 2 for more details on command.)

CONTROL OPERATIONS

4-5. Within C2, control is the regulation of forces and warfighting functions to accomplish the mission in accordance with the commander's intent. Commanders control operations by communicating information to synchronize and direct the actions of subordinate forces. Staffs aid commanders in exercising control by supporting the commander's decision making; assisting subordinate commanders, staffs, and units; and keeping units and organizations outside the headquarters informed. (See Chapter 3 for more details on control.)

ORGANIZE AND EMPLOY THE COMMAND AND CONTROL SYSTEM

4-6. To achieve effective C2, commanders organize and employ the C2 system. Commanders organize their C2 system to support decision making, maintain relevant information, and communicate directives. Once the C2 system is organized, commanders then employ it through the operations process, integrating and synchronizing warfighting functions across multiple domains. Together, these create a framework for effective C2.

Organize

4-7. Commanders organize the personnel within their C2 system to assist them and exercise control on their behalf. They establish clear command relationships and assign responsibilities to empower staff members and subordinate commanders to make decisions at the lowest level. Commanders position key personnel, such as liaisons, to maintain relevant information and promote a shared understanding across the command. Commanders delegate authority to the appropriate individuals, including seconds in command and command sergeants major, to ensure timely decision making and enhance operational effectiveness.

4-8. In addition to organizing people, commanders organize their processes and networks to ensure effective C2. Processes, such as the operations process and integrating processes, structure the activities necessary to support decision making and issue directives. These processes are supported by networks designed to share data that meet information requirements and help create and maintain situational understanding. These networks are accessed through C2 nodes, facilitating the flow of relevant information throughout the organization.

4-9. The final component of the C2 system that commanders organize is C2 nodes. Commanders integrate people, processes, and networks into C2 nodes, which serve as physical and virtual locations for the staff to assist the commander in maintaining visualization and issuing directives. While the configuration of these C2 nodes may vary, it is primarily determined by the missions assigned and the operating environment.

Employ

4-10. The Army's framework for employing C2 is the operations process. The operations process puts the C2 system into action. Commanders, staffs, and subordinate units employ the operations process to integrate and synchronize the warfighting functions across multiple domains and synchronize forces to accomplish missions. This includes integrating processes such as intelligence preparation of the operational environment and the targeting process. The unit's battle rhythm serves as a structured approach to coordinate and synchronize major activities of the operations process.

4-11. The unit's battle rhythm synchronizes the various processes and activities that occur within the operations process. (Refer to FM 6-0 for details on developing the unit's battle rhythm.) Several disciplines help improve the operations process and decision making. This includes critical and creative thinking, data orchestration, data analytics, and knowledge management. (See Chapter 2 for a discussion of critical and creative thinking and Chapter 3 for a discussion of data orchestration, data analytics, and knowledge management.)

COMMAND AND CONTROL SYSTEM

4-12. To effectively exercise C2, commanders are supported by the C2 system. **The command and control system is the arrangement of people, processes, data and networks, and command and control nodes that enable commanders to conduct operations.** This system is shown in Figure 4-2.

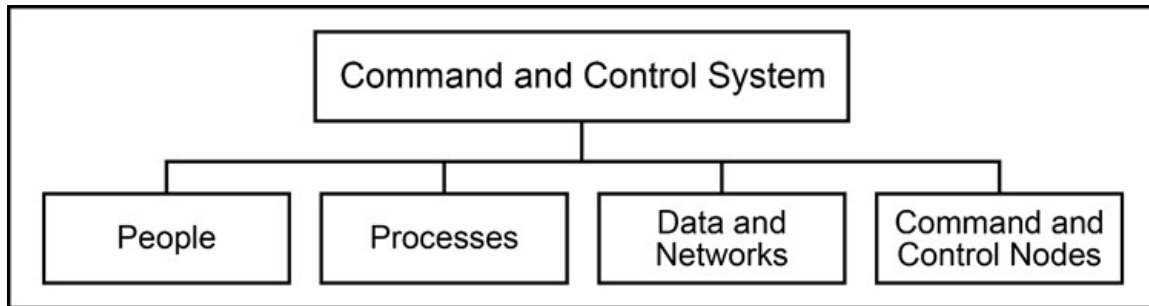


Figure 4-2. Components of the Command and Control System

4-13. The C2 system is not just equipment; it is all the resources used to support C2. While it can be enhanced by technology (such as artificial intelligence and machine learning), the C2 system begins with people. Since combat involves Soldiers, no amount of technology can reduce the importance of the human dimension. Commanders base their exercise of C2 on human characteristics more than on processes, data and networks, and C2 nodes.

4-14. The C2 system performs three basic functions, as shown in Figure 4-3. First, it helps commanders achieve and maintain situational understanding. Second, it regulates forces and warfighting functions by supporting commanders' decision making. This includes producing and disseminating orders. Third, it allows the force to adapt to change throughout the operations process.

Support situational understanding	Regulate forces and warfighting functions	Allow the organization to adapt to change
- Collect, process, display, store, and disseminate information. - Assess the status and performance of the subordinate units and the progress of operations. - Anticipate opportunities or threats in execution.	- Support the commander's decision making. - Develop specific directives from commander's guidance. - Define limits. - Allocate resources to requirements and tasks. - Direct operations by producing and disseminating orders. - Acquire means to accomplish the mission.	- Forecast change in the operational environment; determine the meaning of that change. - Identify variances in performance from the concept of operations. - Report significant changes in the situation to the commander and higher, lower, adjacent, and supporting and supported units.

Figure 4-3. Functions of the Command and Control System

4-15. The key to employing the C2 system lies in allocating enough resources to support the exercise of C2 while maintaining the effectiveness of other warfighting functions. The C2 system avoids wasting resources through unnecessary duplication, although some redundancy is necessary for continuity of operations. An effective C2 system allows the commander to—

- Communicate with forces and unified action partners.
- Delegate authority to subordinate commanders and staffs to allow decentralized execution of operations.
- Synchronize actions throughout their assigned area.
- Focus on critical actions instead of details.

PEOPLE

4-16. The most important component of the C2 system is people—those who assist commanders and exercise control on their behalf. An effective C2 system accounts for the characteristics and limits of human nature. It exploits and enhances uniquely human skills. People dedicated to the C2 system include commanders, seconds in command, command sergeants major, staff, and liaison officers.

Commanders

4-17. Commanders are responsible for the actions of their subordinates. Commanders may delegate authority, but delegation does not absolve commanders of their responsibility to the higher echelon commander. Commanders are always accountable for what happens, or fails to happen, within their command.

4-18. Where the commander locates within the assigned area, and at what time, are important considerations for effective C2. No standard pattern or simple prescription exists for command presence; different commanders lead differently. Commanders balance their time among the staff sections, subordinate commanders, forces, and other organizations to make the greatest contribution to success. (See Chapter 2 for more discussion on the location of the commander.)

4-19. C2 nodes serve as the focus for information exchange, planning, and analysis. They provide commanders with direct access to staff members and allow them to communicate with superior, subordinate, and supporting commanders. While at a C2 node, commanders provide vital face-to-face guidance to staff members when developing plans and controlling operations. By moving to the locations of subordinates or to critical points in an area of operations, commanders can better assess and influence the state of operations. They personally gauge the condition of their units and leaders and consult directly with subordinate commanders performing critical tasks. By being forward, commanders also motivate subordinates through personal example.

Seconds in Command

4-20. At all levels, the second in command is the commander's principal assistant. The second in command may be a deputy commander, an assistant commander, or the executive officer. Commanders determine the duties and responsibilities of their deputy and assistant commanders. Usually, at company through brigade echelons, the executive officer is the second in command. In a theater army, corps, or division, the deputy or assistant commander extends the commander's span of control in areas and functions that the commander designates.

4-21. Deputy or assistant commanders normally do not have staff. When they have specific responsibilities, the headquarters staff assist them as their commander prescribes. Deputy or assistant commanders may give orders to the staff within the authority the commander delegates to them. They may go to the chief of staff at any time for staff assistance. If a deputy or assistant commander needs to form a team for a specific purpose, the commander may form one from headquarters elements or subordinate units or make a subordinate unit's headquarters available.

4-22. In organizations with more than one deputy or assistant, the commander designates which one is the second in command. Delegating authority to the seconds in command reduces the burden on commanders and allows them to focus on particular areas or concerns while their seconds in command concentrate on others. Normally, commanders delegate authority to seconds in command to act in their name for specific functions and responsibilities. A second in command has important responsibilities in the following circumstances:

- Temporary absence of the commander.
- Succession of command.
- Delegation of authority.
- As deputies of joint and multinational forces.

Temporary Absence of the Commander

4-23. Officers who are second in the chain of command assume duties as delegated, either explicitly or by standard operating procedures, when the commander is temporarily absent or resting. Lack of sleep can impair judgment and creative thinking capabilities. A commander's sleep plan includes delegating authority to the second in command during selected times to give the commander time to sleep. Commanders may also be absent from the command temporarily. In this case, the second in command assumes command temporarily and makes decisions that continue operations in accordance with the commander's intent and policies.

Succession of Command

4-24. Commanders may be killed, wounded, medically incapacitated, or relieved of command. In these situations, the second in command normally assumes command. At brigade and lower echelons, executive officers or senior subordinate unit commanders normally assume command. At higher echelons, deputy or assistant commanders may not be senior to subordinate unit commanders. In this case, the operations order specifies succession of command, and the second in command exercises command until the designated successor assumes command. However, commanders may designate a second in command who is junior to subordinate commanders as their successor in command. (Refer to AR 600-20 for regulatory guidance.)

4-25. Seconds in command must be able to assume command at any time. They must stay informed of the situation. Commanders inform their second in command of any changes to their visualization or intent. The chief of staff keeps the second in command informed of staff actions. Commanders continually train their seconds in command for command at their level.

Delegation of Authority

4-26. Delegating authority to the second in command reduces the burden of commanders' responsibilities. It allows them to focus on particular areas or concerns while their seconds in command concentrate on others. Normally, commanders delegate authority to their seconds in command to act in their name for specific fields of interest and responsibility. Doing this decentralizes decision making while allowing the commander to keep overall command.

As Deputies of Joint and Multinational Forces

4-27. When an Army headquarters serves as the headquarters of a joint or multinational force, appointing a deputy commander from another service or a multinational partner is often appropriate. These deputy commanders may also exercise command over forces of their Service or nation. They serve as important advisers to the Army commander. They facilitate understanding among participating Service or national forces. In this case, succession of command depends on joint and multinational doctrine, law, or international agreement. However, the legal authorities of a multinational deputy may not be the same as a U.S. officer of the same grade. Careful attention is paid to their authority to allocate resources, like Title 10 funds.

Senior Noncommissioned Officers

4-28. The command sergeant major is the senior noncommissioned officer of the command at battalion and higher levels. The first sergeant and platoon sergeant are the senior noncommissioned officers at battery, company, troop, and platoon levels. These senior noncommissioned officers carry out policies and enforce standards for the performance, individual training, and conduct of enlisted Soldiers. They give advice and initiate recommendations to commanders and staffs in matters pertaining to enlisted Soldiers. In operations, commanders employ their command sergeants major and first sergeants throughout the area of operations to extend command influence, assess morale of the force, and assist during critical events. Platoon sergeants perform similar functions at the platoon level.

Staff

4-29. Staff support commanders in making and implementing decisions and in integrating and synchronizing combat power. Effective staff multiply a unit's effectiveness. They provide timely and relevant information and analysis, make estimates and recommendations, prepare plans and orders, assist in controlling operations, and assess the progress of operations for the commander. The primary responsibilities of any staff are to—

- Support the commander.
- Assist subordinate commanders, staff, and units.
- Inform units and organizations outside the headquarters.

Support the Commander

4-30. Staffs support commanders in understanding, visualizing, describing, and assessing the operational environment; making and articulating decisions; and directing, leading, and assessing military operations. Staffs make recommendations and prepare plans and orders for their commander. Staffs use knowledge

management to extract timely and relevant information from the vast amount of available information. Staffs synthesize this information and provide it to commanders in the form of running estimates to help commanders build and maintain their situational understanding.

4-31. Staffs also prepare and disseminate information to subordinates for execution to assist commanders in controlling operations. While commanders often personally disseminate their commander's intent and planning guidance, they rely on their staff to communicate most of their guidance in the form of plans and orders. Staffs communicate their commander's decisions, and the intentions behind them, efficiently and effectively throughout the force.

4-32. Staffs support and advise their commander within their area of expertise. While commanders make key decisions, they are not the only decision makers. Trained and trusted staff members, given decision making authority based on the commander's intent, free commanders from routine decisions. This enables commanders to focus on key aspects of operations.

Assist Subordinate Commanders, Staff, and Units

4-33. Effective staffs establish and maintain a high degree of coordination and cooperation with staffs of higher echelon, lower echelon, supporting, supported, and adjacent units. Staffs help subordinate headquarters understand the larger context of operations. They do this by first understanding their higher echelon headquarters' operations and commander's intent and nesting their own operations with their higher headquarters. They then actively collaborate with subordinate commanders and staffs to facilitate a shared understanding of the operational environment. Examples of staffs assisting subordinate units include performing staff coordination, staff assistance visits, and staff inspections.

Inform Units and Organizations Outside the Headquarters

4-34. Staffs keep their units well informed. Staffs also keep unified action partners informed with relevant information according to security classifications and need to know. Staffs have an obligation to establish working relationships with unit members. As soon as a staff receives information and determines its relevancy, that staff passes that information to the appropriate headquarters. The key is relevance, not volume. Masses of data inhibit mission command by distracting staffs from relevant information. Effective knowledge management helps staffs identify the information commanders and staff elements need and its relative importance.

4-35. Information reaches recipients based on their needs. Sending incomplete information sooner is better than sending complete information too late to matter. When forwarding information, the sending staff highlights key information for each recipient and clarifies the commander's intent. Such highlighting and clarification assists receivers in analyzing the content of the information received to determine what information is of importance to the higher and subordinate commanders. The sending staff may pass information directly, include its analysis, or add context to it. Common, distributed databases accelerate this function; however, they cannot replace the personal contact that adds perspective.

Common Staff Duties and Responsibilities

4-36. Staff members have specific duties and responsibilities associated with their area of expertise. However, all staff sections share a common set of duties and responsibilities. These are—

- Managing information within their area of expertise.
- Building and maintaining running estimates.
- Conducting staff research and analyzing problems.
- Performing intelligence preparation of the operational environment.
- Developing information requirements.
- Advising and informing the commander.
- Providing recommendations.
- Preparing plans, orders, and other staff writing.
- Exercising staff supervision.
- Performing risk management.
- Assessing operations.

- Conducting staff inspections and assistance visits.
- Performing staff administrative procedures.

Characteristics of Good Staff Members

4-37. Good staff members understand how to effectively communicate with their commander, and they discern what information is vital to their commander's ability to C2. They seek a shared understanding of the operational environment with their commander and with the commanders of both higher and subordinate headquarters. This shared understanding includes the commander's visualization of the operational approach, including the commander's intent. Good staff members—

- Are competent. They are experts in doctrine and the processes and procedures associated with their branch or functional area, as well as the operations process. They understand the duties of other staff members enough to accomplish coordination both vertically and horizontally. Staff officers are data literate to evaluate data sources for reliability.
- Bring clarity. They clearly articulate and effectively present information orally, in writing, and visually. They simplify problems in complex operational environments by explaining the meaning of information and not simply providing raw data to the commander.
- Exercise candor. They tell the commander what they believe, not what the commander wants to hear. They are willing to tell the commander both good and bad news. Any staff work eventually affects Soldiers, who execute staff officer recommendations approved by the commander. Staff officers never forget that their recommendations affect Soldiers.
- Exercise initiative. They anticipate requirements rather than waiting for instructions. They anticipate what the commander needs to accomplish the mission and prepare answers to potential questions before they are asked.
- Apply critical and creative thinking. As critical thinkers, staff members discern truth in situations where direct observation is insufficient, impossible, or impractical. They determine whether adequate justification exists to accept conclusions as true. As creative thinkers, staff members look at different options to solve problems. They use proven approaches (drawing from previous similar circumstances) and innovative approaches (coming up with completely new ideas). Staff members use creative thinking to apply imagination and depart from the old way of doing things.
- Are adaptive. They recognize and adjust to changing conditions in the operational environment with appropriate, flexible, and timely actions. They rapidly adjust and continuously assess plans, tactics, techniques, and procedures.
- Are flexible. They avoid becoming overwhelmed or frustrated by changing requirements and priorities. Staff members remain flexible and adjust to any changes. They set priorities when there are more tasks to accomplish than time allows. They learn to manage multiple commitments simultaneously.
- Possess discipline and self-confidence. They understand that all staff work serves the commander, even if the commander rejects the resulting recommendation. Staff members do not give a “half effort,” even if they think the commander will disagree with their recommendations. Alternative and unpopular ideas or points of view assist commanders in making the best possible decisions.
- Are team players. They cooperate with other staff members within and outside their headquarters. This practice contributes to effective collaboration and coordination.

Staff Relationships

4-38. Staff effectiveness depends in part on relationships with commanders and other staffs. Collaboration aids in developing shared understanding and visualization among staffs at different echelons. A staff acts on behalf of, and derives its authority from, its commander. Although commanders are the principal decision makers, individual staff officers make decisions within their authority based on broad guidance and unit standard operating procedures. Commanders insist on frank collaboration between themselves and their staff officers. A staff gives honest, independent thoughts and recommendations, so commanders can make the best possible decisions. Once their commander makes a decision, staff officers support and implement the commander's decision even if the decision differs from their recommendations.

4-39. A staff works efficiently with complete cooperation from all staff sections. A force operates effectively in cooperation with all headquarters. Commanders and staffs foster this positive climate during training and sustain it during operations. However, frequent personnel changes and augmentation to their headquarters adds challenges to building and maintaining the team. While all staff sections have clearly defined functional responsibilities, none can operate effectively in isolation. Therefore, coordination is extremely important. Commanders ensure staff sections are properly equipped and manned. This allows staffs to efficiently work within their headquarters and with their counterparts in other headquarters. Commanders ensure staff integration through developing the unit's battle rhythm and conducting and synchronizing various meetings, working groups, and boards.

Teamwork within a staff and between staffs produces the staff integration essential to synchronized operations.

4-40. The basis for staff organization depends on the mission, each staff's broad areas of expertise, and regulations and laws. While staffs at every echelon and type of unit are structured differently, all staffs share some similarities. (Refer to FM 6-0 for an expanded discussion of staff.)

Liaison Officers

4-41. Liaison is the contact or intercommunication maintained between elements of military forces or other agencies to ensure mutual understanding and unity of purpose and action. Liaison continuously enables direct, physical communications between commands and with unified action partners. Commanders use liaison during operations and normal daily activities to facilitate a shared understanding and purpose among organizations, preserve freedom of action, and maintain flexibility. Liaison provides commanders with relevant information and answers to operational questions, thus enhancing the commander's situational understanding.

4-42. Liaison activities augment the commander's ability to synchronize and converge all elements of combat power into their concept of operation and scheme of maneuver. They include establishing and maintaining physical contact and communication between military forces and nonmilitary agencies during operations. Liaison activities ensure—

- Cooperation and understanding among commanders and staffs of different headquarters.
- Coordination on tactical matters to achieve unity of effort.
- Synchronization of lethal and nonlethal effects.
- Understanding of implied or inferred coordination measures to achieve synchronized results.

4-43. A liaison officer represents a commander or staff officer and makes decisions based on their delegated authority. Liaison officers transmit information directly, bypassing headquarters and staff layers. A trained, competent, trusted, and informed liaison officer is the key to effective liaison. Liaison officers have the commander's full confidence and sufficient experience for the mission. At higher echelons, the complexity of operations requires more senior ranking liaison officers.

4-44. Based on the situation, commanders may receive or request liaison elements (individuals and teams) to assist them with C2. Liaison elements include—

- Liaisons to and from subordinate, adjacent, and supporting units.
- Liaisons to and from unified action partners (refer to JP 3-16).
- An air liaison officer (refer to FM 3-09 and JP 3-09).
- A naval gunfire liaison officer (refer to FM 3-09 and JP 3-09).
- An Army space support team (refer to FM 3-14).
- A special operations liaison officer (refer to ADP 3-05).
- An Army special operations forces liaison element.
- An Army cyberspace operations support team (refer to FM 3-12).
- A theater liaison detachment (refer to ATP 3-94.1).

(Refer to FM 6-0 for more discussion on liaison.)

PROCESSES

4-45. Commanders establish and use systematic processes and procedures to organize activities within their headquarters and throughout the force. Processes are a series of actions directed to an end state, such as the

military decision-making process. In addition to the major activities of the operations process, commanders and staffs use several integrating processes to synchronize specific functions throughout the operations process. The integrating processes are—

- Intelligence preparation of the operational environment (refer to ATP 2-01.3).
- Information collection (refer to FM 3-55).
- Targeting (refer to FM 3-60).
- Risk management (refer to ATP 5-19).
- Knowledge management (refer to ATP 6-01.1).

4-46. Procedures govern actions within the C2 system to make it more effective and efficient. They allow for complex actions to take place without detailed guidance every time the procedure is initiated. For example, standard operating procedures often provide detailed unit instructions on how to configure COP displays. Adhering to processes and procedures minimizes confusion, misunderstanding, and hesitation as commanders make frequent, rapid decisions to meet operational requirements.

4-47. Procedures increase organizational competence by improving a staff's efficiency or by increasing the tempo. Procedures are especially useful in improving the coordination between Soldiers who cooperate to accomplish repetitive tasks, such as the internal functioning of a C2 node.

4-48. C2 procedures are designed for simplicity and speed. When written correctly, they are simple enough to perform quickly and smoothly under conditions of extreme stress and efficient enough to increase tempo. Streamlined staff-planning sequences are preferable to deliberate, elaborate ones.

4-49. Commanders establish procedures to streamline operations and help integrate new Soldiers and attachments. Procedures organize relevant information in standard, easy-to-understand formats and describe routine actions. This includes what C2 nodes are necessary, where to put people in each C2 node, and displacement schedules.

Procedures describe routine actions, thus eliminating repetitive decisions.

4-50. Procedures facilitate continuity of operations when leaders become unable to perform their duties. Subordinates step in and use procedures to continue to operate. When Soldiers are tired or stressed, their decision-making capability is degraded. Standard operating procedures help individuals and units continue to accomplish many tasks because they are routine.

4-51. Procedures do not cover every possible situation. Applying procedures blindly to the wrong tasks or situations can lead to ineffective or counterproductive performance.

DATA AND NETWORKS

4-52. Data and networks are intrinsically linked. Data serves as the fundamental unit of communication and analysis, while networks provide the infrastructure that enables this exchange. Networks facilitate the sharing of data and resources among computers and devices, allowing for efficient information exchange.

Data

4-53. Data is a collection of facts and figures that can be analyzed to derive insights, identify trends, and make predictions. It plays a crucial role in informed decision making by enhancing situational awareness. Through the examination of data, organizations improve operational efficiency and facilitate risk management. Effective utilization of data leads to improved operational processes and outcomes.

Network

4-54. Networks in the C2 system are essential for collecting, processing, storing, displaying, disseminating, and protecting data and information. Networks enable effective C2 operations by facilitating the broad dissemination of relevant information. These networks allow commanders to communicate, make decisions, and direct actions. Commanders establish these networks to connect personnel and enable shared understanding. The Army's primary network, the Department of Defense Information Network-Army, enables internal and external collaboration, efficient information management, order transmission, and the maintenance of situational awareness across the formation.

4-55. Department of Defense Information Network-Army uses network transport and information services to connect users, automated information systems, and applications across the Army enterprise. Network transport encompasses the processes, equipment, and transmission media that provide connectivity and facilitate data movement between networking devices and facilities. This includes devices such as radios, Wi-Fi, microwave and satellite communications, and cables and wires.

4-56. Information services—such as messaging, discovery, collaboration, and storage—enable commanders and Soldiers to collect, process, store, transmit, display, and disseminate information. These services are accessed through end-user applications, such as telephones, tablets, laptops, and various software applications. These allow users to display and share information.

COMMAND AND CONTROL NODES

4-57. C2 nodes serve as locations from which commanders, supported by their staff, direct operations and integrate and synchronize combat power to achieve missions across the spectrum of military operations. Commanders organize the various components of the C2 system into these C2 nodes based on mission requirements and the specific situation, enabling them to effectively exercise mission command. Planning considerations for C2 node organization and employment can be categorized as—

- Those contributing to effectiveness.
- Those contributing to survivability.

4-58. In many cases, these two considerations work in opposition to one another. For example, concentrating staff and systems in fewer, larger C2 nodes enhances collaboration and unity of effort but creates single points of failure and a high payoff target for the enemy. Dispersing functions across many, smaller nodes increase survivability by complicating enemy targeting but can introduce friction and reduce the speed of decision making. For this reason, commanders analyze the mission and associated risks to find an acceptable level of balance between the two.

Effectiveness

4-59. C2 nodes are arranged to facilitate coordination, exchange of information, and rapid decision making. A C2 node communicates with higher echelon, subordinate, adjacent, supporting, and supported units and moves as required. While any individual C2 node can be configured to fulfill any function, no single node can perform all the functions simultaneously. Therefore, effective C2 relies on the integrated and distributed execution of tasks across multiple nodes. The performance of any C2 node is assessed based on its ability to execute the following tasks:

- Building and maintaining situational understanding.
- Conducting planning.
- Conducting data orchestration, data analytics, and knowledge management.
- Controlling operations.
- Assessing operations.
- Coordinating with internal and external organizations.
- Performing C2 node administrative activities.

Building and Maintaining Situational Understanding

4-60. Building situational understanding to support C2 is a primary, collaborative function of all C2 nodes. Staffs transform raw data into knowledge through activities like maintaining running estimates and battle tracking. Technology is instrumental in this effort, enabling mission command systems like the COP to rapidly disseminate information and create a shared understanding across the force. While these systems must be resilient enough to perform in degraded environments, their primary role is to leverage information for a decisive advantage. The resulting knowledge is provided as recommendations. This allows commanders to apply judgment, visualize the operation, and make timely decisions to drive the mission.

Conducting Planning

4-61. Within a C2 node, planning is the primary process for turning situational understanding into a synchronized course of action. The effectiveness of this process comes from the collaboration it creates,

which builds unity of effort among the staff and with subordinate units. This unity of effort is what makes a C2 node effective, as it ensures all actions contribute to a common goal and provides a clear framework for execution. Ultimately, this allows the entire force to operate with disciplined initiative, making the C2 node the central point for driving agile and coherent operations.

Conducting Data Orchestration, Data Analytics, and Knowledge Management

4-62. Effective data orchestration, data analytics, and knowledge management are the engines that transform raw data into situational understanding within a C2 node. Data orchestration ensures the timely flow and integration of information from disparate sources. Data analytics processes that information to identify patterns, assess operational progress, and produce actionable insights. Knowledge management provides the overarching framework to share these insights across the staff, fueling tools like the COP and running estimates. This disciplined process is what makes a C2 node effective, as it provides the commander with the refined knowledge needed for timely decision making.

Controlling Operations

4-63. Controlling operations is the active process by which a C2 node directs, regulates, and synchronizes the force during execution. This function makes a C2 node effective by translating current situational understanding into concrete action, allowing commanders to adapt the plan as conditions change. The C2 node ensures the commander's intent is being met and the force remains unified in its effort by managing resources, deconflicting movements, and synchronizing assets.

Assessing Operations

4-64. Assessing operations is the continuous process of monitoring and evaluating the progress of an operation against the plan, making it the critical feedback mechanism within a C2 node. This function makes a C2 node effective by constantly updating situational understanding by analyzing current information against measures of performance and measures of effectiveness. The recommendations derived from this analysis inform the commander's decisions to either continue the plan, make execution decisions, or make adjustment decisions, ensuring the operation continuously adapts to achieve its objectives.

Coordinating with Internal and External Organizations

4-65. Coordinating with internal and external organizations enables a C2 node to synchronize the broader actions of the force and achieve unity of effort. This continuous interaction with higher and adjacent units—as well as joint, interagency, and multinational partners—is vital throughout the operations process. It expands situational understanding by incorporating diverse information, deconflicts objectives during planning, and ensures mutual support during execution. An effective C2 node acts as a hub for this coordination, allowing it to integrate capabilities beyond its own formation and ensuring its plan is nested within the larger operational framework.

Performing Command and Control Node Administrative Tasks

4-66. Performing C2 node administrative activities encompasses the essential internal tasks that sustain the node, its systems, and its personnel. These activities—which include managing the battle rhythm, maintaining network connectivity and power, and ensuring information systems are functional—are what make a C2 node effective on a fundamental level. A node that excels at these administrative functions can sustain a high operational tempo and ensure the uninterrupted flow of information required for planning, coordinating, and controlling operations. While seemingly routine, this disciplined administration is a direct and vital contributor to mission success that guarantees the resilience of the C2 node, ensuring its ability to exercise C2 continuously.

Note. Standard operating procedures, training, and evaluations consider if C2 nodes can deliver these seven key tasks in both mounted and dismounted configurations and under the demands of both offensive and defensive operations.

Survivability

4-67. The enemy prioritizes friendly C2 nodes as high-value targets. This necessitates a deliberate employment that minimizes detection, complicates enemy targeting, and preserves the ability to perform critical functions under attack or in disrupted, degraded, intermittent, and low-bandwidth conditions. Commanders design C2 nodes to be temporary and reconfigurable, anticipating detection and the need for adaptability over time. This design emphasizes dispersion, redundancy, deception, and rapid reconstitution, rather than relying on the permanence of any single node.

4-68. The enemy conducts systematic counter-C2 operations rather than occasional strikes against C2 nodes. Therefore, ensuring the survivability of C2 nodes requires a comprehensive approach that considers factors such as—

- Size.
- Positioning.
- Dispersion.
- Hardening.
- Signature management.
- Deception.
- Mobility.
- Redundancy.

Size

4-69. A C2 node's size affects its mobility and survivability. Large C2 nodes increase capacity and ease face-to-face coordination. Their size, however, makes them vulnerable to multiple types of detection and attacks. Smaller C2 nodes offer significant advantages—including enhanced concealment, ease of displacement, and a reduced signature—which collectively mitigate the risks associated with enemy targeting. However, C2 nodes that are too small cannot sustain continuous, high-tempo operations. Commanders identify where to accept risk in terms of node size and manning, allocating resources to balance risk and effectiveness over various phases of an operation.

Positioning

4-70. Positioning of a C2 node directly affects its ability to control operations and survive. Commanders weigh the benefit of positioning a C2 node for maximum effectiveness versus the survivability risk to the C2 node. Selecting a location requires thorough analysis of the mission variables of mission, enemy, terrain and weather, troops and support available, time available, civil considerations, and informational considerations.

Dispersion

4-71. Dispersion of C2 nodes involves separating these elements to enhance survivability and reduce vulnerability to enemy targeting. By spreading out C2 nodes, units create a smaller target profile for enemy sensors and weapon systems. This approach complicates enemy detection efforts and reduces both casualties and lost equipment in the event of an attack. Computing and communication technologies enable the C2 system to maximize effectiveness while dispersing to remain survivable.

Hardening

4-72. C2 nodes are hardened to offset electromagnetic or high explosive effects. Electromagnetic hardening is deliberate actions taken to protect personnel, facilities, and equipment. Physical or structural hardening is protection from high explosive effects through the construction of facilities to increase the protection of occupants. Occupying existing hardened facilities and use of engineer assets to harden facilities provide short-term hardening for C2 nodes, especially when dispersion and mobility options are limited.

4-73. Positioning C2 nodes underground—in bunkers, basements, or tunnel systems—whenever mission requirements and terrain allow offers physical protection and reduces visual signatures. However, it presents unique challenges that are addressed in standard operating procedures. These include communications latency, antenna emplacement, ventilation, power provisioning, electromagnetic isolation, and emergency

egress planning. C2 nodes are concealed, preferably underground with overhead cover, during defensive operations or when remaining in one location for extended periods.

Signature Management

4-74. Signature management demands continuous attention to physical and electromagnetic signatures. Emission control plans outline conditional thresholds, authorize burst or directional transmission techniques, and designate remote antenna placements to distance radiating elements from personnel and equipment. Physical signature control measures—camouflage, noise and light discipline—and movement discipline complement emission control measures and pay close attention to avoiding overhead detection.

Deception

4-75. Deception involves misleading enemy observers, focusing surveillance and targeting incorrectly and shifting assets away from actual C2 nodes. To do this, C2 nodes primarily use tactical deception. Tactical deception maximizes the use of deceptive displays, feints, demonstrations, ruses, and diversions to mislead enemy collectors. Successful tactical deception allows the commander to gain an advantage over an enemy force by obscuring C2 node vulnerabilities and enhancing defenses.

Mobility

4-76. C2 nodes deploy efficiently and move within the assigned area as the situation requires. Mobility discipline is essential for enhancing the survivability and operational effectiveness of C2 nodes. C2 nodes are repositioned with enough frequency using irregular movement schedules to hinder detection and targeting.

Redundancy

4-77. Essential functions and critical data are intentionally replicated across multiple C2 nodes to ensure operational continuity. This redundancy allows C2 nodes to continue operations in the event of C2 node movements or losses due to battlefield conditions. In operations, personnel and equipment are lost or fail under stress. Redundancy ensures that the loss or degradation of any single node does not impede a commander's ability to exercise effective C2.

GUIDES TO ORGANIZING FOR COMMAND AND CONTROL

4-78. The C2 system consists of all the resources used to support C2. It enhances the commander's ability to conduct operations. Commanders organize a C2 system to—

- Support the commander's decision making.
- Collect, create, and maintain relevant information.
- Prepare products to support the commander's and leaders' understanding and visualization.
- Prepare and communicate directives.

4-79. How commanders organize a C2 system can complicate or simplify execution. Organizational decisions establish the chain of command (including command and support relationships) and task organization. They influence where commanders obtain information, whom they rely on for advice, and how they supervise execution of their decisions. Organizational decisions affect the structure of the flow of recommendations to commanders. The organization establishes formal communication channels and determines how commanders distribute information throughout their forces.

4-80. Organization provides sources of group identity for soldiers assigned to a command. A command operates most effectively when soldiers consider themselves members of one or more groups characterized by high levels of loyalty, cooperation, morale, and commitment. This supports mission command.

4-81. Information flows vertically within the chain of command, but the organization does not limit its flow to the chain of command. Information also flows laterally among adjacent, supported, and supporting units. Information flows informally and unofficially—between individuals according to personal relationships—and within formal channels. Informal channels provide important redundancy.

4-82. Commanders continually evaluate the organization of their C2 system and adapt to changing circumstances. When organizing for C2, commanders consider several items. These include—

- The chain of command.
- Span of control.
- Unit integrity.
- Degraded environments.

THE CHAIN OF COMMAND

4-83. The *chain of command* is the succession of commanding officers from a superior to a subordinate through which command is exercised (JP 1, Volume 2). The commander at each level responds to orders from a higher commander and, in turn, issues orders to subordinates. In this way, the chain of command fixes responsibility and sources of authority at each echelon while distributing them broadly throughout the force. Each commander has designated authority and responsibility in an assigned area or area of responsibility. Command and support relationships specify the type and degree of authority one commander has over another, and the type and degree of support one commander provides to another. Commanders also have authority over resources, which they allocate to complete the mission.

Command and Support Relationships

4-84. Establishing clear command and support relationships is fundamental to organizing for operations. These relationships prescribe clear responsibilities and authorities among subordinate and supporting units. Some forces are given command or support relationships that limit their commander's authority to prescribe additional relationships. Knowing the inherent responsibilities of each command and support relationship allows commanders to establish clear responsibilities when organizing their forces. (Refer to FM 3-0 for more information on command and support relationships.)

4-85. Commanders designate command and support relationships within their authority to support the concept of operations. Task organization helps subordinate and supporting commanders understand their roles in the operation and contribute to achieving the commander's intent. Command and support relationships carry with them varying responsibilities to subordinate units by parent and gaining units.

Allocating Resources

4-86. Mission command requires commanders to have authority over, or access to, all resources required to accomplish the mission. Accordingly, commanders organize resources and forces when making organizational decisions. Resource organization does not violate unity of command and supports unity of effort. This organization or allocation of resources has minimum restrictions on their use, permitting subordinates to further reallocate or to employ them as the tactical situation requires.

SPAN OF CONTROL

4-87. Organization ensures reasonable span of control, which refers to the number of subordinates or activities under the control of a single commander. An effective organization enables the commander and subordinate commanders to command without information overload. The commander establishes their span of control to exercise C2 under all circumstances, including in degraded environments. A commander's span of control does not exceed that commander's capability to command effectively. The optimal number of subordinates varies based on the situation; in fluid and rapidly changing environments, a commander can effectively supervise fewer subordinate elements. Conversely, having a greater number of subordinates can enhance flexibility and provide more options and combinations.

4-88. Narrowing the span of control—that is, lessening the number of immediate subordinates—deepens the organization by adding layers of command. The more layers of command in an organization, the longer it takes for information to move up or down the organization. Consequently, the organization may become slower and less responsive. On the other hand, an effort to increase tempo by eliminating echelons of command or flattening an organization requires widening the span of control. Commanders balance width and depth, so that the C2 organization fits the situation.

UNIT INTEGRITY

4-89. Effective commanders are flexible; they task-organize forces to suit the situation. This includes creating nonstandard, temporary teams or task forces. However, commanders reconcile the need for organizational flexibility with the requirement to create shared understanding and mutual trust. These characteristics result from familiarity and stable working relationships.

4-90. Commanders consider the impact on mission command when task-organizing forces. Whenever possible, commanders task-organize based on standing headquarters and habitually associated elements. When this is not feasible and organizations are formed from a wide variety of units, commanders allow time for training and establishing functional working relationships and procedures.

4-91. Once a force is task-organized and committed, commanders do not change the task-organization during operations unless the benefits clearly outweigh the disadvantages. Reorganizations cost time, momentum, effort, and tempo. Commanders also consider logistics factors, as the time required to change task organization may counter any organizational advantages.

DEGRADED ENVIRONMENTS

4-92. When organizing for C2, commanders consider the impact of degraded environments on the C2 system. The C2 system may be degraded as the result of hostile actions to contest the use of the cyberspace and space domains or due to the lack of resources to provide sufficient network coverage in an area of operations. The degradation may not be technological. The use of electronic warfare, radiological or nuclear weapons, and adverse weather may create physical conditions that cause interference in the electromagnetic spectrum and degrade the C2 system. The challenges of communicating while wearing chemical or biological protective masks and the corrosive effects of chemical agents and decontaminants on communications equipment may also degrade C2. All of these may interfere with a commander's ability to exercise C2.

4-93. To mitigate this risk and successfully conduct operations in degraded environments, commanders cannot become overly reliant on technological capabilities. Commanders ensure their personnel are trained on analog and manual C2 processes and are comfortable operating in degraded environments. Understanding the functions performed by automated systems is critical to understanding what functions are performed in an analog environment. Commanders ensure standard operating procedures are in place that will help the C2 system maintain its ability to function. Personnel are trained and proficient in—

- Continuous operations.
- Maintaining the COP.
- Manual information sharing.
- Staff integration and crosstalk.
- Manual running estimates.
- C2 node battle drills.

4-94. One way to deal with degraded communications is through primary, alternate, contingency, and emergency communication planning. This establishes the primary, alternate, contingency, and emergency methods of communications, typically from higher echelons to lower echelons. Establishing this plan requires care that an alternate or contingency method of communications does not rely on the primary. The key to a good plan is to establish redundancy so that communications are always available. Most units will have two primary, alternate, contingency, and emergency plans: one for communications to higher echelon headquarters and one for subordinate units. A plan for a higher echelon headquarters will likely be established by that headquarters.

4-95. Ultimately, the doctrinal solution to operating in degraded environments is mission command. Even under severely degraded conditions, Army forces continue to make decisions and act in the absence of orders, when existing orders no longer fit the situation, or when unforeseen opportunities arise.

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Source Notes

This division lists sources by page number.

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Glossary

The glossary lists acronyms and terms with Army or joint definitions. Where Army and joint definitions differ, (Army) precedes the definition. The proponent publication for terms is listed in parentheses after the definition.

SECTION I – ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

ADP	Army doctrine publication
AR	Army regulation
ATP	Army techniques publication
C2	command and control
CCIR	commander's critical information requirement
COP	common operational picture
DA	Department of the Army
FM	field manual
JP	joint publication
MCTP	Marine Corps training publication
NVA	North Vietnamese Army
U.S.	United States

SECTION II – TERMS

Army team building

A continuous process of enabling a group of people to reach their goals and improve their effectiveness through leadership and various exercises, activities and techniques. (FM 6-22)

battle rhythm

(DOD) A deliberate, daily schedule of command, staff, and unit activities intended to maximize use of time and synchronize staff actions. (JP 3-33)

chain of command

(DOD) The succession of commanding officers from a superior to a subordinate through which command is exercised. (JP 1, Volume 2)

command

(DOD) 1. The authority that a commander in the armed forces lawfully exercises over subordinates by virtue of rank or assignment. (JP 1, Volume 2)

command and control

(DOD) The exercise of authority and direction by a properly designated commander over assigned and attached forces in the accomplishment of the mission. (JP 1, Volume 2)

***command and control node**

A scalable and survivable configuration of the command and control system designed to enable commanders to effectively command and control operations.

***command and control system**

(Army) The arrangement of people, processes, data and networks, and command and control nodes that enable commanders to conduct operations.

command and control warfighting function

The related tasks and a system that enable commanders to exercise authority and direction to accomplish missions. (ADP 3-0)

commander's critical information requirement

(DOD) Specific information identified by the commander as being essential to facilitate timely decision making. (JP 3-0)

commander's intent

(DOD) A clear and concise expression of the purpose of an operation and the desired objectives and military end state. (JP 3-0)

***commander's visualization**

The mental process of developing situational understanding, determining a desired end state, and envisioning an operational approach by which the force will achieve that end state.

***common operational picture**

(Army) A display of relevant information within a commander's area of interest tailored to the user's requirements and based on common data and information shared by more than one command.

***control**

The regulation of forces and warfighting functions to accomplish the mission in accordance with the commander's intent.

***control measure**

A means of regulating forces or warfighting functions.

***data**

Data is unprocessed figures, signals, or observations from the environment (physical and virtual) that can be transmitted or processed to improve situational understanding.

***data analytics**

The process of transforming sets of data to identify patterns, trends, and insights.

***data literacy**

The ability to read, understand, and evaluate data.

data orchestration

The process of synchronizing, integrating, and prioritizing data to enhance shared understanding and decision making. (ATP 6-0.7)

***essential element of friendly information**

A critical aspect of a friendly operation that, if known by a threat, would subsequently compromise, lead to failure, or limit success of the operation and therefore should be protected from enemy detection.

friendly force information requirement

(DOD) Information the commander and staff need to understand the status of friendly force and supporting capabilities. (JP 3-0)

***graphic control measure**

A symbol used on maps and displays to regulate forces and warfighting functions.

***information**

In the context of decision making, data that has been organized and processed in order to provide context for further analysis.

***information management**

(Army) The science of using procedures and information systems to collect, process, store, display, disseminate, and protect data, information, and knowledge products.

joint force

(DOD) A force composed of significant elements, assigned or attached, of two or more Military Departments that operate under a single joint force commander. (JP 1, Volume 1)

***key tasks**

Those significant activities the force must perform as a whole to achieve the desired end state.

***knowledge**

In the context of decision making, information that has been analyzed and evaluated for operational implications.

***knowledge management**

An integrating process that enhances knowledge flow to improve shared understanding, decision making, organizational performance, and learning.

leadership

The activity of influencing people by providing purpose, direction, and motivation to accomplish the mission and improve the organization. (ADP 6-22)

***mission command**

(Army) The Army's approach to command and control that empowers subordinate decision making and decentralized execution appropriate to the situation.

***mission orders**

Directives that emphasize to subordinates the results to be attained, not how they are to achieve them.

multidomain operations

The combined arms employment of joint and Army capabilities to create and exploit relative advantages to achieve objectives, defeat enemy forces, and consolidate gains on behalf of joint force commanders. (ADP 3-0)

multinational operations

(DOD) A collective term to describe military actions conducted by forces of two or more nations, usually undertaken within the structure of a coalition or alliance. (JP 3-16)

operation

(DOD) 1. A sequence of tactical actions with a common purpose or unifying theme. (JP 1, Volume 1)

operational approach

(DOD) A broad description of the mission, operational concepts, tasks, and actions required to accomplish the mission. (JP 5-0)

operational environment

(DOD) The aggregate of the conditions, circumstances, and influences that affect the employment of capabilities and bear on the decisions of the commander. (JP 3-0)

operational initiative

The setting of tempo and terms of action throughout an operation. (ADP 3-0)

operations process

The major command and control activities performed during operations: planning, preparing, executing, and continuously assessing the operation. (ADP 5-0)

priority intelligence requirement

(DOD) The intelligence component of commander's critical information requirements used to focus the employment of limited intelligence assets and resources against competing demands for intelligence support. (JP 2-0)

***relevant information**

All information of importance to the commander and staff in the exercise of command and control.

risk

Probability and severity driven chance of loss, caused by threat or other hazards. (ATP 5-19)

***situational understanding**

The product of applying analysis and judgment to relevant information to determine the relationships among the operational and mission variables.

task organization

(Army) A temporary grouping of forces designed to accomplish a particular mission. (ADP 5-0)

task-organizing

The act of designing a force, support staff, or sustainment package of specific size and composition to meet a unique task or mission. (ADP 3-0)

***understanding**

In the context of decision making, knowledge that has been synthesized and had judgment applied to comprehend the situation's inner relationships, enable decision making, and drive action.

unified action partners

Those military forces, governmental and nongovernmental organizations, and elements of the private sector with whom Army forces plan, coordinate, synchronize, and integrate during the conduct of operations. (ADP 3-0)

unity of effort

(DOD) Coordination and cooperation toward common objectives, even if the participants are not necessarily part of the same command or organization that is the product of successful unified action. (JP 1, Volume 2)

warfighting function

A group of tasks and systems united by a common purpose that commanders use to accomplish missions and training objectives. (ADP 3-0)

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07 July 2026

By Order of the Secretary of the Army:

CHRISTOPHER C. LANEVE

*General, United States Army
Vice Chief of Staff*

Official:

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'M. Sannito', with a stylized flourish at the end.

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